A PRACTICAL PLAYBOOK · 2026

THE ESSAY-LED CREATOR PLAYBOOK

Replicating the Dan Koe model as a solo writer: ideas, audience, newsletter, offers and launches.

Prepared for Jonathan Nott
Jono's Journal · jonathannott.substack.com
Built from 238 letters (222 free, 16 paid), summarised in original words

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Tags used throughout: **DEMO** = something the source says it did. **OPINION** = a claim or recommendation. Treat both as evidence to test, not as guarantees.

START HERE

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Start here

How the whole system fits together, and how to use this book.

- → How to use this playbook
- → The Koe model on one page
- → What this playbook is built from
- → What is different about Jono's Journal
- → Five questions to answer before you start

How to use this playbook

Read it in order once, then work it in the order of Part 8. Parts 1 to 7 teach one layer each. Part 8 tells you which week to do what. Do not wait to finish reading before you start writing. The model Koe describes is a practice, and the playbook assumes you learn it by doing.

TIME PER PART

Part	First read	Doing the exercises
1 Foundation	45 min	2-3 hours
2 Idea System	60 min	4-5 hours, then ongoing daily habit
3 Free Writing and Audience	60 min	ongoing, 30-60 min a day
4 Newsletter	60 min	ongoing, one essay a week
5 Offer and Ladder	60 min	4-6 hours
6 Courses and Products	75 min	10-20 hours to build a first product
7 Landing Pages and Launch	60 min	6-10 hours plus a three-week launch window
8 90-Day Plan	45 min	13 weeks at about two hours a day

A full first read is roughly eight hours. Spread it across the first two weeks of the plan.

HOW EXERCISES WORK

Every exercise has four parts: a **prompt** (what to do), a **time box** (how long, and you stop when it ends), a **deliverable** (a concrete thing you can point to: a list, a page, a published post), and a **check** (one question that tells you whether you did it). If you cannot name the deliverable, you have not done the exercise. Reading an exercise and thinking about it does not count.

Exercises are tagged by theme in Appendix A, so you can find the one you need when you are stuck.

HOW TO KEEP AN EVIDENCE LOG

Koe's whole approach rests on testing against reality: he says to publish, watch the response, and adjust. OPINION You cannot do that if you only remember the results you liked. Keep a single running document, or one note per week, with these headings:

1. **Date and week number.**
2. **What I published** (title, format, where, link).
3. **What I expected** (one line, written before you publish).
4. **What happened** (numbers from the dashboard in Part 8, plus any replies worth keeping).
5. **What I think it means** (one line, held loosely).
6. **What I will change** (one concrete change, or "nothing, keep going").

Write step 3 before you publish. Otherwise hindsight edits your memory. Review the log every Sunday and at weeks 4, 8 and 12. The log is also your future material: the best essays often start as a pattern you spotted in your own results.

The Koe model on one page

Here is the system as a map. Read it left to right, then read the loops.

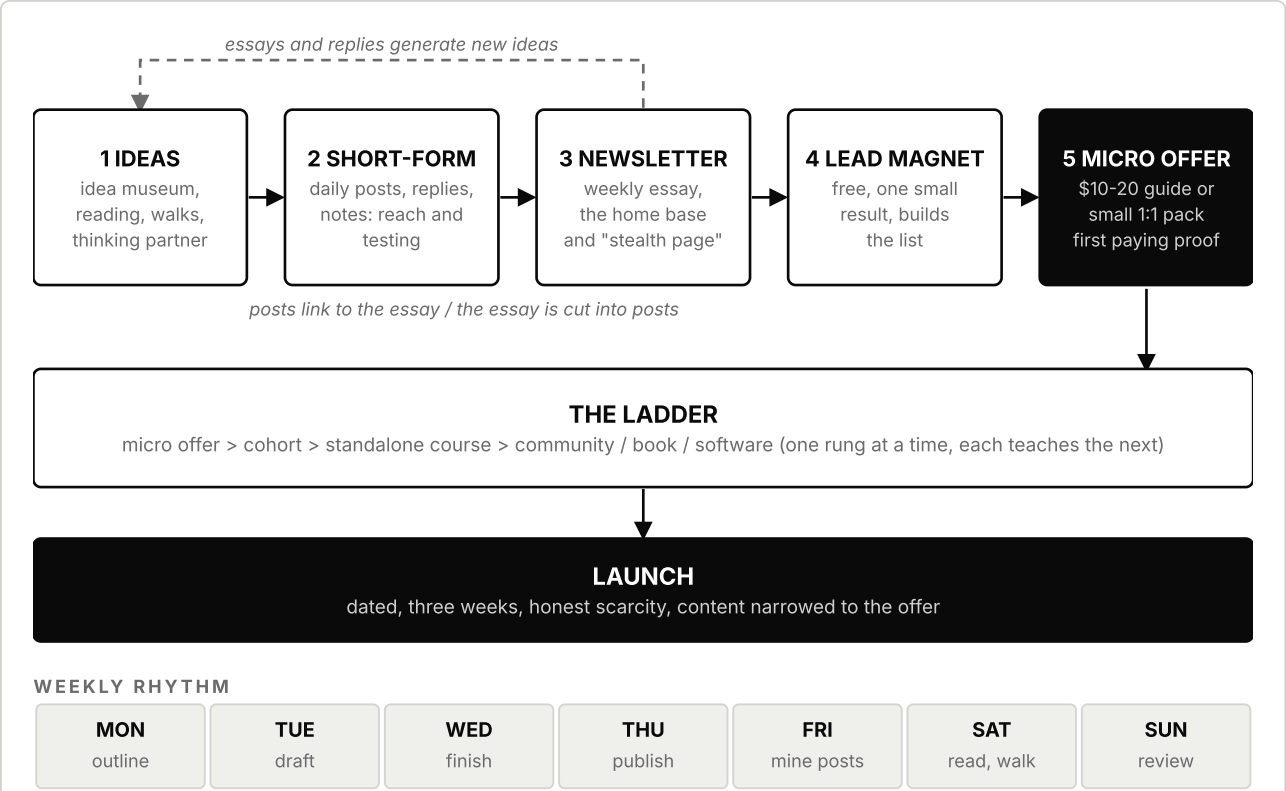


Figure 1. The whole system on one page: ideas feed short-form, short-form feeds the newsletter, the newsletter feeds the offer.

THE STAGES IN PLAIN WORDS

1. **Ideas.** You collect other people's strong ideas, filter them through your own goals and experience, and name them. The raw material is reading, walking, conversation and your own failures. Ideas come from a curated intake, not from the feed.
2. **Short-form.** Several small posts a day on one text platform. Their job is reach and testing. A post that over-performs is a signal that the idea has pull. DEMO
3. **Newsletter.** One long piece a week. It is where you build trust, show you can think, and place offers. Koe treats it as the center of the system: posts are written from it, linked to it, and tested into it. DEMO
4. **Lead magnet.** A free, small, useful thing in exchange for an email, or simply a best-performing essay made easy to find. It turns visitors into a list you own.
5. **Micro offer.** The first thing anyone can pay for: a small guide at roughly ten to twenty dollars, or a small service such as four calls at roughly five hundred to a thousand dollars. DEMO / OPINION The point is proof that someone will pay and a conversation with your first customers.
6. **Ladder.** Each step up is more help for more money: a guide, then a cohort or course, then a standalone product, and much later a community, a book or software. Koe says to sequence these over years, and he describes launching something new about every quarter for years. DEMO
7. **Launch.** A dated event with a deadline, run over about three weeks, supported by content that narrows to the product topic. DEMO

THE FEEDBACK LOOPS

- **Short-form tests, newsletter develops.** A post that wins becomes an essay. An essay is cut into posts to drive readers back. Nothing is wasted.
- **Replies feed ideas.** Questions people ask in replies and DMs are the cheapest market research. A question that keeps coming back is a product topic.
- **Sales feed content.** If an offer does not sell, Koe's diagnosis is usually traffic, promotion or the offer, rarely the page design. OPINION You adjust the content and the promotion first.
- **Customers feed the product.** Calls with early buyers become the curriculum. His phrase for it is that coaching notes become the course. OPINION

THE WEEKLY RHYTHM

Day	Main work (about two hours)
Monday	Outline the week's essay; collect ideas; plan 5-7 short posts
Tuesday	Draft the essay (60 min); short posts (30 min); engagement (30 min)
Wednesday	Finish the essay; short posts; engagement and DMs
Thursday	Publish; link the essay under the day's best short post; engagement
Friday	Short posts mined from the essay; one offer mention; DMs
Saturday	Light: reading and a walk for ideas; reply to readers
Sunday	Review dashboard and evidence log; set next week's one change

This is adapted to a solo essay writer from the two-hour daily schedule Koe describes: about an hour on the newsletter on most days, thirty minutes on posts, thirty on engagement and linking. DEMO You will tune it in Part 8.

Legend

Everything the playbook says about Koe's practice carries a tag.

Tag	Meaning
DEMO	Koe says he did this, or shows it in his own work. It is a report of practice, and it is self-reported.
OPINION	Koe asserts this as advice or belief. He may be right. It is not evidence.

Anything without a tag is the playbook's own recommendation or interpretation. Where the playbook disagrees with Koe, it says so.

What this playbook is built from

Sources. 222 free letters by Koe (his earlier site-era letters and his later Substack letters, roughly 2021 to 2026) and 16 paid letters that were supplied to the playbook author. The work was done from paraphrased notes on those letters, not from the original text. Nothing here is a quotation from Koe beyond a short phrase here and there, and none of his prompts are reproduced. The prompts in Appendix C are original.

Limits you should hold in mind.

- **AI-assisted summarization.** The notes were produced with AI help. Summaries compress and sometimes flatten. A detail may be missing, merged or slightly off. When a decision matters, go and read the original letter.
- **Self-reported results.** Every revenue, audience and conversion figure comes from Koe about himself. None is audited. Some are round numbers, some are marketing claims inside promotional letters, and a few moved between letters. Treat them as direction, not as data.
- **Survivorship bias.** You are studying a person who succeeded. For every creator who followed a similar path, many are invisible because they stopped or did not grow. The model may be necessary, sufficient, neither or both. You cannot tell from his letters.
- **Scale difference.** Koe describes an audience that, by his account, reached into the hundreds of thousands of newsletter readers and millions of followers. Percentages and benchmarks that work at that scale do not transfer to a list of thousands. Also, many of his tactics assume a large text platform presence that you may not have.
- **Selling bias.** Many letters promote his courses, software or cohorts. The advice often points toward what he sells. Read his tool recommendations and product-led tutorials with that in mind.
- **Time drift.** The letters span about five years. His own advice changed: from service-first to audience-first to AI-assisted. Tactics tied to specific platforms and tools age fast.

What is different about *Jono's Journal*

Koe's most visible output is a mix of practical business advice and personal philosophy. The audience he built through that mix is largely made up of beginners, which he says repeatedly is most of any market. OPINION Your starting point is different in four ways, and each changes how you should apply the model.

1. **You are essay-led.** Koe says essays and articles differ: an article packages answers, an essay works out a belief. OPINION He argues essays are the slow content that survives a flood of fast content. This favors you, because you already write what he recommends. Your risk is the opposite of the usual beginner's: you may write well and package poorly (weak titles, no clear reader, no next step).
2. **Your readership is general and philosophical, not a "how to make money" audience.** Most of Koe's funnel assumes readers want a business outcome. Your readers may read for ideas, voice and reflection. The ladder may need to be built around thinking, writing or reading, rather than around business.
3. **Your list is in the thousands.** That is a real asset. Koe describes tiny audiences earning money through a small product and a handful of clients. DEMO / OPINION At your size, the limiting factor is more likely the offer than the traffic.
4. **Your platform is Substack.** Notes, recommendations and the subscribe flow are built in. Several of Koe's tactics (a public newsletter archive used as a sales page, one daily link under a best post) map directly. Others (custom landing pages, cohort tooling) need extra tools.

The playbook does not assume more than that about you. The five questions below are how you fill in the rest.

Five questions to answer before you start

Answer these in writing, in the evidence log, before week 1. Keep each answer to a few sentences. Then revisit them at week 4. Do not try to answer all of them well on the first pass. Answer them honestly and let the work refine them.

1. What is the goal: views, subscribers, or paying readers? These pull in different directions. Views reward broad, shareable pieces. Subscribers reward depth and a reason to return. Paying readers reward a specific, bought outcome. If you pick all three, which loses when they conflict? What would you stop doing to protect the one that matters most?

2. Who is the one reader you are writing for, and where are they now versus where do they want to be? Koe's anchor for this is writing for your past self, with a starting point and a destination. OPINION Can you describe that reader's day, and the specific thing they would pay to change? If you cannot, what would you need to learn, and from whom?

3. What will the first offer be, and who will you make it to? Not the tenth offer: the first. Would it be a short guide, a small paid series, a set of calls, a reading list, a workshop, or something else? What is the smallest thing a reader could pay for that proves the idea? Which three people on your list could you ask this week?

4. Which of your assumptions about the model would you most like to be wrong? For example: that you must sell, that you must niche (or not niche), that more output means more growth, that philosophical writing cannot be monetized, that Koe's path is a good fit. Pick the assumption you are most attached to and write what evidence would change your mind.

5. What are you willing to stop doing for 90 days? Two hours a day does not appear from nowhere. What will you drop? If nothing, what does that say about how serious the plan is, and what is the smaller version you would actually keep?

Done? Go to Part 1.

PART 01

01

Foundation

Know what you stand for, who you serve, and what you want to be known for.

- → Write your anti-vision and vision (the mission)
- → Draw a content map instead of picking “topics”
- → “You are the niche”: mission-based positioning and the avatar
- → Profile, bio and pinned post
- → Find your intellectual signature (core ideas)

Introduction

Koe's system starts well before any post. In his own account, the sequence is: decide what you stand for and against, turn that into a map of ideas, make yourself the reference reader, package it in a profile that tells a stranger what they will get, and identify the handful of ideas you will repeat for years. Tactics come after. He says as much in several letters: tactic-collecting is cheap stimulation, and position comes first (see: The Art of Strategic Thinking, 2026).

Two honesty notes before you begin.

- **Tags.** DEMO means Koe says he did the thing, with figures where he gave them. OPINION means he asserts it works or should work. Almost nothing here is independently verified. His revenue and audience numbers are self-reported, he runs a software company and several courses that benefit from the advice, and we only see the people for whom his path worked. Treat him as a rich source of hypotheses, not proof.
- **Scale.** He reports audiences in the millions and many letters sell something. Jono's Journal is an essay-led publication with thousands of subscribers. Some of Koe's logic (funnels, challenges, price ladders) belongs to Parts 3 onward. This part is only the foundation, and it transfers well because it is mostly about thinking, not selling.

Lesson 1.1: Write your anti-vision and vision (the mission)

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION He treats a brand as a transformation, not a topic. The reader should be able to say what life they leave behind (the anti-vision) and what life they move toward (the vision). He calls the rejected life the "enemy" and says a brand needs one to rally against. His own enemy, by his account, was the default school-job-retire life. (see: The Content Map, Aug 2025; The Most Profitable Niche In The Creator Economy Right Now, May 2025)
- OPINION People follow for one of three reasons: entertainment or education, interest in a topic, or a belief that you can change their life. He ranks the third highest.
- DEMO He keeps a running note of experiences he never wants to repeat, then inverts the list into a draft vision. He suggests a 30-minute "minimum viable vision" that you revise later, not a finished manifesto. (see: Disappear and come back unrecognizable; The Fastest Way To Create A New Life)
- DEMO After renaming his newsletter around a clear mission, he says his ideas "flooded back" after a dry spell. The mission acted as a filter: anything read or watched could be asked, "does this help people become X?" (see: The Most Profitable Niche In The Creator Economy Right Now)
- OPINION The same pair of lists doubles as your niche: you attract people one or two steps behind you who want to leave the same life.

WHY IT WORKS

A mission converts the unbounded question "what should I write about?" into a bounded one: "does this move my reader from A toward B?" It also supplies conflict, and conflict is what makes essays readable. The anti-vision is usually the emotionally stronger half, because most people can say what they dislike more clearly than what they want. The caution: it can drift into a pose. If the enemy is a straw figure, the writing turns into scolding.

DO IT

1. Write 10 lines beginning "I never want to…" about the life, thinking habit or working pattern you reject. Be specific; "a calendar run by other people's priorities" beats "being unhappy".
2. Circle the three that you have actually lived, not just feared. Those carry credibility.
3. Invert the three into three lines of vision: what the reader's life looks like when they have left that place.
4. Merge into two sentences: "I write for people stuck in [A]. I help them move toward [B]." Treat this as a draft you test against your next ten essays.

Element	Koe's version	Your draft (fill in)
Enemy / anti-vision	Default path, assigned goals, scrolling-as-life	
Vision	Self-directed work and a body of work that belongs to you	
Reader at Point A	Lost, busy, consuming	
Reader at Point B	Clear, building, publishing	

Lesson 1.2: Draw a content map instead of picking "topics"

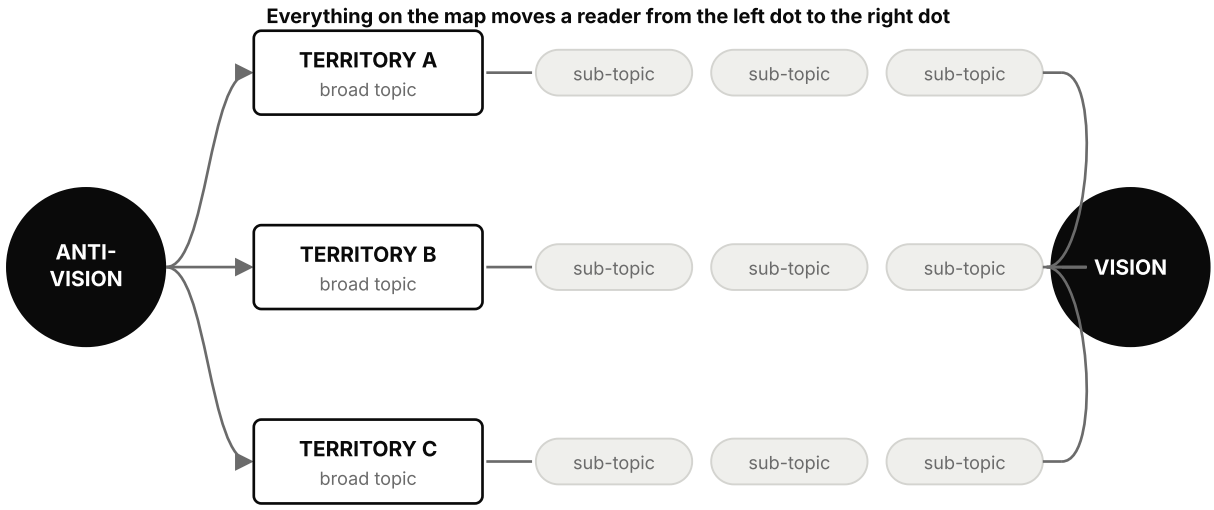


Figure 2. A content map: three broad territories between the life you reject and the life you want.

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION His slogan is that posts are puzzle pieces of a map, not darts thrown at random. (see: The Content Map, Aug 2025)
- DEMO The method, done on paper: put the anti-vision and vision as two anchor dots; add 2-3 broad territories; give each 3-5 sub-topics; give each sub-topic 3-5 specific ideas. Idea types he lists: pain points, how-tos, lessons learned, why-it-matters pieces, harsh truths, takes on popular ideas, contrarian opinions. Then draw lines between unrelated nodes to see combinations.
- DEMO An earlier version he calls a topic tree: list interests, go broad and relatable first, narrow only in the product. Another version: outline your life as a ten-chapter book (story, philosophy, education, practice) and treat each chapter as a source of letters. (see: How to create your niche of one; The Anti-Niche)
- DEMO A later AI-assisted version: 3-4 pillars, 5-7 topics each, 5-10 ideas each, 4-5 angles per idea, which he says yields roughly six months of material. (see: The most lucrative AI business to start in 2027)
- OPINION Treat it as a magnet for ideas, not a checklist. You are not obliged to fill every cell.

WHY IT WORKS

Most writers experience idea scarcity as a talent problem. A map turns it into a coverage problem: you can see which territory has no pieces yet. It also protects against two failure modes: writing only what you happen to feel like (random, hard to follow) and writing only what trends (no through-line).

DO IT

- Use paper. The physical constraint forces you to choose what goes on it.

- Keep the map visible. When you capture a new idea, give it a cell. If it fits none, decide whether to expand the map or discard the idea.
- Revisit it quarterly. Mark cells that produced your best-performing essays.

Lesson 1.3: “You are the niche”: mission-based positioning and the avatar

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION He says niching down by topic boxes you in. Topic niches reward niche-hopping and punish people with several interests. His alternative is mission-based positioning: the throughline is a transformation, so any idea that serves it is fair game. In a later letter he walks back the bare “you are the niche” slogan and says both approaches work and the choice depends on personality. (see: The Most Profitable Niche In The Creator Economy Right Now; The Anti-Niche; You don’t need a niche, you need a point of view)
- OPINION The avatar is you, or your past self. Write down your starting point, what triggered change, what an ideal day looks like now, what you achieved that others want, and how your topic bridges the two. Ask who you can help most (default: yourself a few years ago), what changed your life most, and how you could help others do the same.
- OPINION Teach from one or two steps ahead, not ten. Being a visible learner is acceptable; you do not need a result to share what you learned.
- OPINION He argues the market cannot saturate because audiences follow personalities and perspectives, not topics, and because creators and followers evolve. That is a claim, not a finding.
- DEMO His own career: web design, then funnels, then creator content, then software, each pivot made possible by a brand not tied to a single topic. He also says about 5% of his early content was about web design, the thing he sold. (see: The Most Profitable Niche In The Creator Economy Right Now)
- OPINION Brand is what accumulates in a reader’s head over three to six months of reading you, not what the bio says on the first visit. People follow perspectives, not information. (see: The Death of the Personal Brand)

WHY IT WORKS

An essayist’s comparative advantage is judgment and voice, which cannot be copied the way a how-to topic can. Making yourself the avatar means you already know the reader’s pain, in their own words, because you wrote it in a journal. It also removes the need to fake expertise.

DO IT

Write a one-page avatar brief about yourself as reader:

- Where I was three years ago (specific: what I read, what I did on a Tuesday evening).
- The trigger that changed it.
- Where I am now.
- What I would tell that earlier person, in three ideas.
- Why they would care (benefits and costs, not features).

Then choose, deliberately, between the two positioning styles and write down why. If you choose mission-based, state the mission in one sentence and keep it nearby.

Lesson 1.4: Profile, bio and pinned post

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION Profile photo: clear and high contrast, legible at thumbnail size. Bio: say what you write about and what the reader gets, in the form “I write about X, Y, Z so you can [outcome]”. He explicitly steers away from “I help X do Y” templates, partly because they read as sales copy and partly because they narrow the brand. (see: One-Person Business Launchpad course, May 2025; The one-person business revisited)

- OPINION Link the bio to the newsletter, not to a bare opt-in page. His reasoning: a public newsletter archive is both a lead magnet and a stealth sales page, because a stranger can sample your best work first. (see: How to Build a World, May 2025)
- OPINION Pinned post: one of three types — your best-performing piece, your origin story, or a beginner-level action post. Keep the timeline clean enough that a new visitor sees a coherent body of work. His test for a profile: does it look like an account with a large following, and does it answer "what's in it for me?" (see: The Simple 3 Point Online Business Model)
- OPINION Visitors to a profile decide within seconds; the first screen has to signal both quality and direction.

WHY IT WORKS

A stranger arriving from one viral piece has no context. The profile, the bio, and the pinned item are the three places you control that first impression. For a Substack publication, the equivalent surfaces are the publication name and tagline, the About page, and the welcome post or featured post.

DO IT

- Draft five versions of your bio in his formula, then three without it. Read them aloud to someone who has never seen your work. Keep the one they can repeat back.
- Pick your pinned/featured essay by evidence, not affection: highest saves, shares or new subscribers attributed.
- Audit your last ten posts against your mission. Archive or unpin anything that contradicts it.

Lesson 1.5: Find your intellectual signature (core ideas)

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION A brand is a curated collection of your best ideas, in your words. The best speakers repeat 5-10 core arguments for years. He says differentiation comes from connection and articulation, not novelty: nobody owns a topic. (see: Turn 1 idea into 1000, Sep 2025; Prompt: find your intellectual signature, Jan 2026)
- DEMO He describes a five-phase process (summarized, not reproduced): excavate your influences, the problems you keep returning to, and the explanations you repeat; research the thinkers behind them; synthesize a mission; crystallize 3-5 ideas that pass a "could I write a book on this" test; output a blueprint. He runs it as an AI-led interview. The user, not the model, chooses the mission.
- DEMO A client version has nine question groups: who you help, your story, who shaped your mind, pillars and angle, beliefs, what you are against, why now, where you take readers, rules and named concepts. Then: gather 10-20 past pieces and have a model summarize core ideas, voice traits and implied worldview. If you do not publish yet, list 5-10 people who shaped your thinking and extract their best ideas; your originality is the remix. (see: The most lucrative AI business to start in 2027)
- DEMO His own edge, by his account, is connecting domains that rarely meet: philosophy, psychology and developmental theory with business and creator work. His results rose, he says, when he stopped studying business directly and read philosophy and psychology, then recast the principles in plain terms. (see: The Synthesizer, 2023)
- DEMO He writes a "knowledge base" document of his own recurring frameworks and feeds it to an AI as context. He admits it took about 30 hours and many rereads. (see: A Complete Knowledge Base Of HUMAN 3.0)
- OPINION Repeat the core ideas endlessly. "Content creation is programming; repetition needed."

WHY IT WORKS

Repetition with variation is how an audience learns what you are for. A reader who can summarize your three big ideas to a friend becomes a distributor. It also turns writing from an endless search for topics into an elaboration of a few convictions, which is what an essayist is anyway.

DO IT

1. List your last 20 essays or notes. Underline claims you made in more than one.
2. List 10 books, thinkers or experiences that changed your mind, with the one idea each gave you.
3. Pick the 3-5 claims that survive the book test: could you write 30,000 words on it, from experience, without padding?
4. Give each a working name (Part 2 shows how) and one-line definition.
5. Store these in one document. This is your signature sheet. Feed it to an AI only as context for critique, never to ghostwrite.

EXERCISES (PART 1)

Each has a timer and a deliverable. Do them in order.

- ☐ **A. Anti-vision dump (20 min).** Ten "I never want to…" lines, three circled, three inverted. *Deliverable:* one page titled "Anti-vision / vision".
- ☐ **B. Mission sentence (15 min).** Write the two-sentence mission from Lesson 1.1. Test it against your last five Jono's Journal essays: score each 0-2 for how clearly it serves the mission. *Deliverable:* a five-row score table and a note on the lowest scorer.
- ☐ **C. Content map (60 min, paper).** Two anchors, 2-3 territories, 3-5 sub-topics each, 3-5 ideas per sub-topic. Draw at least ten cross-links. *Deliverable:* a photo of the map plus the five ideas you most want to write.
- ☐ **D. Avatar brief (30 min).** Complete Lesson 1.3's one-pager as your past self. *Deliverable:* one page, plus three phrases that reader would actually say.
- ☐ **E. Bio and pinned post (30 min).** Five bios in his formula, three outside it; choose one by the read-aloud test; pick a featured essay by data. *Deliverable:* final bio, final featured essay with a one-line reason.
- ☐ **F. Signature sheet (90 min, can split).** Follow Lesson 1.5. *Deliverable:* a document with 3-5 named core ideas, each with a definition and the experience behind it.

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 1)

Answer in writing, in a few honest sentences each.

1. **Is a "enemy" right for an essay publication?** Koe's brand runs on conflict with a villain (the default path, the 9-5, the scroller). Essays for a general readership may do better with curiosity, nuance and fairness. Which of your best-loved pieces had an enemy, and which had a question? What would you lose if you gave up the enemy, and what would you gain?
2. **Do you want a mission or a topic?** Koe's mission-based approach suits broad thinkers, but his own audience grew when his content was beginner-level and promised a clear transformation. If your readers come for how you think, not for a result, is "move reader from A to B" the right frame, or does it quietly turn your essays into self-help?
3. **Who is surviving the survivorship bias?** Koe's route (broad content, strong persuasion, a product at the end) worked for him and he reports it at huge scale. What evidence would convince you it works at a few thousand readers without a product? And what would you do differently if you stopped treating "audience growth" as the main goal and judged essays by depth of reader response?

PART 1 RECAP

Start from what you reject and what you want instead; write both down; use them as the filter for everything you read and write. Convert that into a map, so ideas have places to live and gaps are visible. Make yourself the reader: you are the niche only if you can describe your past self precisely. Make your profile, bio and featured piece tell a stranger in seconds what they will get. Then distill your three to five core ideas, name them, and commit to repeating them. Everything in Part 2 assumes this foundation: without a mission and a map, an idea system collects clutter instead of material.

PART 02

02

The Idea System

Collect, test and name ideas so you never face a blank page.

- → Build an idea museum
- → Idea density: choose sources that are packed
- → Validate topics against what already performs
- → Structures to swipe: posts and essays
- → Name your concepts
- → Paradoxes, contrasts and reframes
- → Plain-language explanation for beginners
- → Problem, insight, solution, and recurring framings
- → The thought-partner method
- → Koe's recurring concepts: a glossary

Introduction

Koe's output rests on a pipeline, not on inspiration: capture constantly, read from idea-dense sources, check what already works, choose a structure, write, and use a conversation partner (human or AI) to sharpen the thinking. He says writer's block is a shortage of ideas, not of words; the fix is input and processing (see: Full guide: how to start writing long form, Jan 2026). He is firm that AI should not write for him: AI is for research, dissection and questioning; the words must come from his own mind (see: You have about 36 months to make it).

This part covers the pipeline, then the articulation habits that make his letters feel distinctive, then a glossary of the concepts he keeps reusing so you can see how repetition builds a vocabulary.

Lesson 2.1: Build an idea museum

WHAT KOE DOES

- DEMO He captures ideas the moment they appear, mostly on a phone while walking, and keeps two kinds of notes: ideas for long pieces and ideas for standalone short posts. (see: How to Build a World; The influencer is dead. The Age of Experience is here.)
- DEMO The museum has at least two boards: **Validated** (posts and titles that already performed, by others or by you) and **Favorite** (ideas you personally love). The best piece merges one from each, filtered through your viewpoint.
- DEMO He runs one topic per week: one board or note where ideas, links and PDFs collect, and the week's letter is written from it. He tried two topics a week and found one better because attention gathers around a single theme. (see: The writing habit that saved my brain, Jul 2026)
- OPINION Capture only what produces a spark of excitement. Indiscriminate highlighting is hoarding. When an idea grips you, stop reading and do three things: ask what use it has, tie it to your goals, restate it in your own voice. (see: How I Hunt For Viral Ideas; How to copy your way to success)
- DEMO He gives away an "Idea Museum" swipe file as a lead magnet.

WHY IT WORKS

Ideas collected without a mission become a pile; ideas collected under a mission become inventory. The excitement filter is crucial: it means the museum reflects your taste, which is the thing that cannot be copied.

DO IT

- Create two lists in whatever you already use: "Validated" and "Favorite". One rule for each entry: one sentence in your words, plus where it came from.
- Add a third list: "Objections I hear in my head". Disagreements are idea seeds.
- Set a weekly theme and move 5-10 entries into it on Monday.

Lesson 2.2: Idea density: choose sources that are packed

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION Find 3-5 idea-dense sources: old or little-known books, curated blogs and accounts, and a short list of creators you open on purpose instead of scrolling a feed. Novelty comes from books, not timelines. (see: Turn 1 idea into 1000; The Greatest Skill Of The 21st Century)
- DEMO Habits: walks with audiobooks or long lectures tied to a current project, three books in rotation, rereading a favorite book when stuck, and "hunting" for one or two golden nuggets per sitting and then stopping. (see: Reading: Change Your Life with One Simple Habit; The Minimalist Productivity System)

- DEMO The “10-minute creative” routine: read something aligned with your interests, jot what excites you, summarize in 3-5 bullets in your own words with your experiences, then compress to one sentence written like a quote. (see: The 3-Habit Morning Routine to End Procrastination)
- OPINION Read with a lens. Two people reading the same book get different ideas if they have different goals; a project or mission is the lens. Reading summaries strips the context that changes your thinking.
- OPINION Reading is 80% of the writing job. He spends more time on research than on structure and voice.
- DEMO Idea source stacking: read two unrelated articles and write a piece that connects them. (see: Full guide: how to start writing long form)

WHY IT WORKS

Density beats volume. One book that stretches you yields more usable material than fifty threads that repeat the consensus. The lens turns passive reading into hunting.

DO IT

1. Choose three dense sources you can reread (one old book, one curated newsletter or blog, one thinker you disagree with).
2. Block 30 minutes daily to read with a question in mind. Stop at the first idea that grips you.
3. Write that idea as one sentence tied to a Jono’s Journal reader’s life.

Lesson 2.3: Validate topics against what already performs

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION The best ideas sit where **performance** (proven interest) and **excitement** (your genuine curiosity) overlap. Either alone fails: all-performance is trend-chasing; all-excitement is a private diary. (see: How to remember everything you read… don’t, Jul 2026; How to build a better personal brand than 99% of people)
- DEMO Research order of reliability for what to write: (1) your own best posts and letters; (2) top ideas from creators in your space (sort by popularity, log titles); (3) audience replies and recurring questions; (4) calls with beginners; (5) products and emails of mentors. (see: Mega Guide, May 2025)
- DEMO Packaging versus substance: he reused the idea behind an old “get ahead of 99% of people” post as a video title, filled it with fresh content, and reports 1.7M views; other creators later used the same title. His point is that topics are not ownable, but your content under them is. (see: Growing on social media is easy, actually; The influencer is dead)
- DEMO He reverse-engineers outliers: list 5-10 admired writers, scan their feeds, mark posts at roughly twice their normal engagement, and ask why each works (idea, sentence shape, word choice, psychology). Outliers from small or mid-sized accounts are the real signal; celebrity virality is noise.
- OPINION When growth stalls, slot in a validated-topic piece to bring readers toward more esoteric ideas. Position a niche idea under a popular angle.
- OPINION Test ideas on short posts first; the one that wins becomes the essay’s title or section.

WHY IT WORKS

It reduces the cost of being wrong about demand. For an essayist, the risk is the opposite: letting “validated” override what is true or interesting to you.

DO IT

- Make a “performance sheet”: your 10 best-performing Jono’s Journal pieces, with title, shape of hook, and the one-sentence idea.
- Add 10 outlier pieces from other writers you respect, with the same columns.
- Score each of your 5-10 candidate topics 0-2 for performance and 0-2 for excitement. Write only those scoring 3+, and write at least one 4/4 in every month.

Lesson 2.4: Structures to swipe: posts and essays

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION Most people have a structure problem, not an idea problem. Save structures separately from ideas, and plug yours into someone else's skeleton. Copy structure or content, never both from one source. (see: How to escape beginner hell as a creator; 3 Drills to master short-form posts)
- DEMO **Drill method:** write down ten mediocre ideas; take ten saved structures; for each, first write why the structure works (hook opens a loop, novel truth, implied before/after, polarizing filter), then rewrite one idea in it. A second drill: force ten post ideas from one long source. A third: study fast-growing creators' top posts and rewrite validated ideas in your take.
- DEMO **One idea, five angles:** how a thinker you love would say it; to your past self; redefine it; the common view versus your disagreement; why it matters to the everyday reader. (see: The influencer is dead)

Essay skeletons he uses (summarized):

Skeleton	Shape	Where it suits
Pain & Process	Pain in the intro, steps to fix it	Beginner pieces, quick posts
Pain, Concept, Process	Adds a deeper concept for novelty	Intermediate essays
Perspective, Advantage, Gamify	Common view, better view, step-by-step "game"	Advanced essays
Big idea, Problem, Amplify, Solution	Two sections only	Short newsletters
Pyramid Principle	Conclusion first, 3+ arguments, evidence	Argued essays
Problem, Insight, Solution	Story shape; his default for thinking pieces	Almost anything
Classic copy frameworks (PAS, AIDA, PASTOR)	Persuasion scaffolds	Promotions; use as training wheels

- DEMO **Piece anatomy:** one topic idea (title); 3+ key point ideas (section heads); 3-5 filler ideas per key point. For deep topics, 2-3 key points, each built from a quote, a definition, a plain explanation, an example, an application and an action. Hook of 200-500 words attacking the "enemy" (past self, common view, average behavior) and promising a transformation. (see: Full guide: how I write about deep ideas and still go viral, May 2025)
- OPINION Hook craft: show what most people get wrong, via story or direct statement; add a micro summary, number, or quote. Hook types seen across letters: confession, provocative claim, rhetorical question with blunt answer, surprising anecdote, definition then flip, letter-to-past-self, reader-callout list, plea.
- DEMO Letters often include an up-front promise or agenda, claim-style section heads, Roman numerals or numbered steps, one-sentence paragraphs, an epigraph, a recap, and a sign-off. Longer pieces warn the reader about length and why it is worth it.
- DEMO The weekly workflow: outline at the start of the week, add ideas in the draft on your phone during walks, write in a dedicated block, then derive posts from the finished piece. (see: How to learn anything 10x faster than anyone with AI)

WHY IT WORKS

Structures are cheap to borrow and impossible to see until you dissect them. Writing "why this works" in your own words is the learning step; skipping it produces imitation without understanding.

DO IT

- Collect 15 structures from essays you finish reading, not skim. For each, write the skeleton in 5-8 bullets (no content).
- Rewrite one idea in three different skeletons and compare. Keep the best.
- Ask an AI to dissect a piece you admire (macro and micro structure); never ask it to write yours.

Lesson 2.5: Name your concepts

WHAT KOE DOES

- DEMO Nearly every letter contains a named framework: Fill-Empty-Use, Time Under Attention, Three Narrowers of the Mind, Identity-Lifestyle Fit, Tactical Stress, the Swap Test, Koe's Law, Koemmandments. Names are often borrowed from another domain and transposed: product-market fit applied to a person; time under tension applied to attention; macronutrients applied to brand and content. (see: Why your life feels fake; Make Millions With Your Mind; The future of work when work is meaningless)
- DEMO He coins a label for every loop he notices, and uses compound or paired forms: X for Y ("Vision for Direction"), triads, 2x2s, versioned numbers ("3.0"), alliterative lists, and "-or" puns. (see: Learn this skill if you want to stay relevant in 10 years; HUMAN 3.0)
- OPINION Names come after the explanation: write out the process you already use, then produce ~5 candidate names and sleep on them. A name should hold in a title and be easy to repeat. Baking a timeframe or outcome into the name makes it sell. (see: Mega Guide; The $1 Million Product)
- DEMO The improvised version: during one letter he created a five-part list on the spot, pairing it with an earlier framework, and told the reader he had done so.

WHY IT WORKS

A named idea is a handle. Readers can quote it, search for it, and carry it into conversation. Over time, a stack of handles becomes a brand vocabulary, so a new reader can tell they are in one particular mind.

DO IT

For each core idea on your signature sheet, write: the plain-language definition, the contrast ("this, not that"), one metaphor from a domain you love, and three candidate names. Choose one, then use it in the next three essays so it sticks.

Lesson 2.6: Paradoxes, contrasts and reframes

WHAT KOE DOES

- DEMO Reframe moves, repeated in dozens of letters: take a popular belief and flip it (discipline is easy, not hard; a flaw like being disagreeable is evidence you are on the right path; distraction is closed-mindedness; you are not broken, you are questless). (see: Self-Discipline Is Easy, Actually; How To Be More Disagreeable; You're not broken, you just don't have a quest)
- DEMO Hook templates: accept the critic's frame in the title ("a giant Ponzi scheme") and then argue it fairly; quote a viral claim, partly agree, then twist its premise; state the objection voice ("But what about AI slop?") and answer it.
- DEMO The three-option move: enemy A, enemy B, synthesis (Purists, Automatons, and the third path). Define a thing by its opposite first (what stupid thinking is), then derive its better form. Close with a paradox ("intense yet unbothered").
- OPINION The thought-partner prompt he uses explicitly hunts four things: patterns where you differ from standard practice, paradoxes where the opposite works better, unnamed processes you already use, and contrasts between two types. (see: The Greatest Thought Partner Prompt, Jul 2025)
- OPINION Conviction beats hedging. He argues over-qualifying kills action and slight exaggeration helps the point land, with nuance added in follow-up. He recommends aiming for a post that about 90% like and 10% dislike. This is a stylistic choice, not a truth claim.

WHY IT WORKS

Contrast is how the mind registers a new idea. A reframe gives the reader an immediate shift in how they see something familiar, which is the closest thing to a "free" insight. The risk is that reframes can be glib if they are not backed by an example or reasoning.

DO IT

Take five beliefs your readers hold (from your own previous life). For each, write: the common view, the flip, the evidence from your life, and the one situation where the flip fails. If you cannot state where it fails, you are not ready to publish it.

Lesson 2.7: Plain-language explanation for beginners

WHAT KOE DOES

- OPINION About 90% of the market are beginners; write for them, even on deep topics. Write for your past self, define obscure terms in plain language with examples, and accept the length. This is his answer to “how do you write deep ideas for a mass audience?” (see: Full guide: how I write about deep ideas and still go viral)
- DEMO Pick a dense, obscure model (a four-quadrant map, a developmental ladder, a theory of flow), translate it into a few plain boxes, then run one concrete problem through it with sample questions. He names this as the way he explains big models. (see: How to think like a genius)
- DEMO The Feynman habit: explain a concept to a four-year-old with metaphors, fill the gaps you find, then study opposing views. Rename borrowed models in your own terms and credit the source openly. (see: The Matrix Is Real)
- DEMO One extended metaphor, mapped across several domains, as the spine of a long piece (a video game for life, nutrition for information, fitness for the mind). He admits “all understanding is metaphorical” and uses it deliberately.
- OPINION Ideas change when they pass through a viewpoint; the same compound-interest idea reads differently as wealth advice versus habit advice. Your lens is the thing that adds value to a borrowed idea. (see: You don’t need a niche, you need a point of view)
- DEMO Structure of a definition: short definition, plain explanation, example, application, action.

WHY IT WORKS

Clarity is the scarce good. Readers reward the writer who makes a hard idea feel obvious, and the explanation exercise exposes gaps in your own understanding before you publish.

DO IT

Pick one idea you find hard to explain. Write it for a 12-year-old in 300 words, with one metaphor and one example. Then rewrite for your normal reader keeping the metaphor. Mark every jargon term and either cut it or define it on first use.

Lesson 2.8: Problem, insight, solution, and recurring framings

WHAT KOE DOES

- DEMO His default frame is Problem, then Insight, then Solution. Reasons he gives: the problem captures attention, qualifies the reader, starts a story, opens a curiosity loop and frames the solution. Many letters start from a personal problem and show how he overcame it. (see: How to think originally; How to remember everything you read… don’t)
- DEMO Before drafting he fills in a short checklist: the big problem, the desired outcome, the aha insight, the unique process, a novel concept, an optional timeframe. For product-leaning pieces: problem, goal, process (his “value equation”).
- DEMO The same handful of ideas appears across hundreds of letters (see the glossary), each time with a fresh example or metaphor. He even builds new pieces from his own old tweets, which he says validated the framework first, then expanded into a letter. (see: Why Productivity Advice Is Ruining Your Life; The 3-Part Daily Routine)
- DEMO Seed from a conversation, comment or objection. Several letters began from a friend’s remark, a reader comment or a critic’s tweet. (see: The Uncertainty Crisis; Self Improvers Are Creating Their Own Careers Online)
- OPINION Most creators in a topic circle the same 5-10 ideas. Growth is slow, then bursts; keep milking the idea that worked and expect it to expire.

WHY IT WORKS

Repeating a small set of ideas through changing examples builds depth and recognition. The problem-first frame is a known retention technique, but it can push essays toward the diagnosis-and-fix shape every time.

DO IT

- For your next essay, fill in the six-item checklist before you write a sentence.
- Keep a “second appearances” list: each of your core ideas should appear in a different guise at least once every six essays.

- Scan old reader replies for one comment you can turn into the next opening.

Lesson 2.9: The thought-partner method

WHAT KOE DOES

- DEMO Before writing, he gives an AI a topic and has it interview him, one question at a time, until he has reached several breakthroughs. He says he does this before most things he writes. Then he asks it to organize the breakthroughs into an outline for a newsletter, a video or several posts. (see: The Greatest Thought Partner Prompt, Jul 2025; AI will never replace true creators)
- DEMO Rules baked into the prompt (summarized): one question at a time; no flattery; keep pushing on generic claims until they become specific; do not leave a concept until it has a name; avoid empty business words; stop when there is enough material. Each insight is then written up with the breakthrough, a short explanation, how it changes your world, your own phrasing, an outside reframe and a distinctive name.
- DEMO Other prompts of the same family: idea extraction from a source (his own writing, a transcript or a book) into idea types such as paradoxes, big ideas, pain points, objections and action steps, producing “micro-article” outlines; a prompt that generates 50+ candidate ideas across fixed idea types; a prompt that dissects an admired piece. He says AI cannot write posts that feel right, and one commenter’s test of AI-expanded outlines produced generic prose. (see: How I generate deep post ideas with AI)
- DEMO He states that his letters are handwritten, with AI used for research, ideation and drafting only for marketing tasks he dislikes. (see: You have about 36 months to make it)
- OPINION Use AI to remove friction (structure options, research, directions), not to supply opinions.
- DEMO Getting unstuck without AI: problem, quote, explanation, example, metaphor, statistic, goal, action. (see: Full guide: how I write about deep ideas)

WHY IT WORKS

Questions do what blank pages cannot: they force specifics. Talking an idea out surfaces your actual position, and a patient interviewer with no ego pushes past the first, generic answer. The method has a long human equivalent: a friend, editor or Socratic partner.

DO IT

Run this with a human or an AI. Give the partner a rule list from the bullet above (one question at a time, no compliments, force specifics, name the unnamed). Spend 20 minutes on one essay topic. Record the three sentences you were surprised to say. Write the essay’s first draft from those, with the transcript closed.

Koe’s recurring concepts: a glossary

Described in my own words. Seeing them together shows how a small vocabulary is reused across hundreds of letters.

Concept	What it means in Koe’s usage
Anti-vision / vision	The life you refuse versus the life you move toward; used to derive goals, brand and content.
Minimum viable vision	A short, revisable draft of your desired future, written quickly.
You are the niche / niche of one	Position around your own experience and worldview, not a topic.
Point A / Point B	Where the reader is now versus where they want to be; the brand’s transformation.
Content is the map; product is the tool	Posts give pieces of the territory (what and why); a product gives the full route (how).
Idea museum	A swipe file of captured and validated ideas.
Intelligent imitation	Copy structure and technique from admired work, add your own experience.
Nobody owns a topic	The packaging can be borrowed; your content under it is yours.

Concept	What it means in Koe's usage
Performance x excitement	The overlap between what proves popular and what you care about.
Entropy / centropy (psychic entropy)	Disorder of attention versus effortful order; cheap dopamine versus earned.
Flow / edge of abilities	Challenge that matches skill; too easy is boredom, too hard is anxiety.
Hierarchy of goals	Ten-year, one-year, monthly, weekly, daily goals cascading from the vision.
Tactical stress	A deliberate public deadline that forces you to finish.
Value creator	Someone who researches, solves their own problems and shares the results.
Specialized generalist / digital renaissance	Depth plus breadth across fields, as a strategy against AI commodity work.
Eternal markets	Health, wealth, relationships, happiness: the permanent problem areas.
Transcend and include	A stage builds on and keeps the previous one rather than rejecting it.
NPC / main character / programmer	Levels of agency: reacting, choosing, designing the rules.
Cheap vs earned dopamine	Quick stimulation versus reward from progress.
Build a world	A body of work you can binge, like a film universe, instead of a funnel.
Taste / swap test	Curation judgment; test whether a creator could be swapped out without loss.
Fill-Empty-Use	Input in the afternoon, brain-dump at night, creation in the morning.
Time under attention	The attention-minutes a reader gives you; long form earns more.
Public journal	Treat posting as documenting your learning and addressing your past self.
Nothing happens, then everything happens	Growth is delayed and lumpy; persistence precedes visible results.

EXERCISES (PART 2)

- ☐ **A. Museum setup (20 min).** Create the Validated, Favorite and Objections lists. Add five entries to each. *Deliverable:* three lists with fifteen entries.
- ☐ **B. Source selection (30 min).** Name three idea-dense sources. Read 20 minutes from one with your mission as the lens. *Deliverable:* one-sentence idea plus its source.
- ☐ **C. Performance sheet (45 min).** Your top ten Jono's Journal pieces plus ten outliers from others, with hook type and core idea. *Deliverable:* a 20-row table and three patterns you spot.
- ☐ **D. Topic scoring (15 min).** Score five candidate topics on performance and excitement. *Deliverable:* ranked list and the one you will write.
- ☐ **E. Structure drill (60 min).** Dissect three admired essays into skeletons. Rewrite one idea of yours in two of them. *Deliverable:* three skeleton cards and two 150-word openings.
- ☐ **F. Five angles (30 min).** Pick one idea from the museum; write the five angles from Lesson 2.4. *Deliverable:* five sentences; pick the strongest as a title.
- ☐ **G. Name it (30 min).** Take one unnamed pattern from your own life, produce five names, definition and contrast. *Deliverable:* one named concept card.
- ☐ **H. Reframe sheet (30 min).** Complete the five-belief reframe exercise of Lesson 2.6, including where each flip fails. *Deliverable:* five rows, one where the flip fails marked.
- ☐ **I. Explain it simply (30 min).** Lesson 2.7's 12-year-old rewrite. *Deliverable:* 300 words plus jargon list.
- ☐ **J. Thought-partner session (45 min).** Run Lesson 2.9 on an upcoming essay. *Deliverable:* three surprising sentences and an outline with Problem, Insight, Solution.

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 2)

1. **Does “validate first” fit essays?** Koe starts from what already performs and fits his idea under that. Essays often succeed because they are unexpected. If you only wrote what the data says, would Jono’s Journal still be recognizably yours? Name one essay you would write even if it were certain to underperform, and say why.
2. **Is a named concept always a gift?** Koe names everything, which builds recall but can make ideas sound like products, and sometimes the label outruns the thought. For which of your ideas would a plain sentence be more honest than a coined term? What is the cost to your credibility if readers sense branding in place of thinking?
3. **Whose thinking is it?** The thought-partner method and the “borrow, rename, refract” habit rely on outside models and tools. Where is the line, for you, between synthesis and repackaging someone else’s work? And how would you know, six months from now, that a conviction in your essay is truly yours rather than something a prompt or a favorite thinker handed you?

PART 2 RECAP

Koe’s idea system runs on capture, density, validation and structure: keep a museum of validated and favorite ideas under your mission, read from a few dense sources with a lens, check ideas against what already performs while keeping your excitement, and borrow structures rather than content. His distinctive articulation comes from naming concepts, building contrasts and reframes, explaining deep ideas in plain words for beginners, and returning to the same few ideas in new clothes. The thought-partner method adds a questioning step before drafting, so the writing comes from your own sharpened position. Take the discipline and the questions; weigh the persuasion tactics carefully against what your essays and readers need, remembering that his evidence is self-reported and comes from a very different scale.

PART 03

03

Free Writing and Audience Growth

Reach new readers with daily writing and honest distribution.

- → Free writing is the top of the funnel, so write broad and for beginners
- → Build short-form skill with drills, not inspiration
- → Post structures and hooks
- → Borrow validated topics, supply your own angle
- → The content ecosystem, levels 1 and 2
- → The 2-hour daily schedule
- → Traffic mechanisms: replies, quote posts, reposts, DMs
- → Remix, curation and crediting
- → Tribes and masterminds
- → Short form builds, long form keeps
- → Paid growth, platform risk and ethics (honest and caveated)
- → Sample 7-day post plan (generic template)

Introduction

Dan Koe's growth model is simple to state. Free, short, broad writing on social platforms attracts strangers. A weekly long-form letter turns some of them into readers who trust him. Offers sit behind the letter. This part covers the first layer: the daily free writing, the schedule that keeps it cheap, and the mechanisms that put it in front of new people.

How to read the claims below. Every item is tagged. DEMO means Koe says he did it, with figures where he gave them. OPINION means he asserts it without showing it. Almost everything is self-reported. His audience is in the millions across platforms, and he had a head start (he began on Twitter in 2019 and grew with the platform's early-adopter wave). We only hear from the people who made it, so the reported tactics are not a controlled test. A tactic that worked at 5,000 followers may behave differently at 500, or on a platform with different mechanics. Treat each lesson as a hypothesis to test over weeks, not a law.

Jono, you write essays for a general readership and already have thousands of subscribers. That puts you ahead of Koe's beginner advice in one way (you have a base) and behind it in another (essays are slower to produce and harder to compress into posts). Each lesson ends with a "Do it" step adapted to Substack Notes and your format.

Lesson 1: Free writing is the top of the funnel, so write broad and for beginners

What Koe does. He treats social posts as the widest part of a funnel. He tells people to write for beginners because he believes most of any audience is new to the topic (he puts it around 90-95%) OPINION. He says to cover a few broad topics rather than a narrow niche, to open most posts with a pain point or a "why should you care" angle, and to save the detailed how-to for the newsletter or a product OPINION. A pre-send checklist he gives: why should anyone care, what pain does this touch, how does it help an ordinary person. He says about 80% of short posts should start from a pain point and that the basics should be repeated often because people need reminders more than novelty OPINION. He also describes keeping about 80% of content on the topic he will sell and 20% on side interests DEMO/OPINION.

Why it works. Strangers scrolling a feed are not searching for anything. A post has to give them a reason to stop that does not depend on already knowing you. Broad, pain-first openers do that. Keeping the detail for later also gives the newsletter a job that posts can't do.

Do it.

- Before posting, ask the three-question checklist above. If you can't answer "why would a stranger care", rewrite the first line.
- For Jono's Journal: your essays are probably more reflective than pain-first. Don't change the essays. Change the Notes. Use the Note to name the problem the essay circles, and let the essay hold the nuance.
- Keep a rough 80/20 split between your main themes and experiments, and review after a month.

Lesson 2: Build short-form skill with drills, not inspiration

What Koe does. In a paid post he describes three drills, each producing about ten posts, so one sitting gives weeks of material DEMO, AS DESCRIBED:

Drill	Method (paraphrased)	Skill built
1. Structure transplant	Collect ten saved post structures. For each, first write down why it works (it opens a loop, states a surprising truth, implies a before/after, filters the audience). Then pour one of your own ideas into it without copying the hook.	Seeing structure
2. Extraction	Consume one long source (book, video, podcast) and force out ten post ideas, written without templates.	Idea generation
3. Validated-idea rewrite	Study the most popular posts of 5-10 fast-growing creators in your area. Note ideas that repeat. Rewrite them through your own view.	Market sense

He adds that most creators in a topic circle the same 5-10 ideas, so repetition is normal OPINION. He also says to keep a swipe file of 10-20 favourite posts open while writing, and to review output every few months to see what performed and promote those themes into your pillars DEMO. He describes reverse-engineering admired writers by collecting posts that did about twice their usual engagement and writing a few bullets on why each worked DEMO. His summary: most people have a structure problem, not an idea problem OPINION.

Why it works. Short posts are a craft with learnable parts: hook, turn, close. Drills isolate those parts so you practise them directly rather than hoping a good post appears. Copying structure while changing content avoids both plagiarism and the blank page.

Do it. Run drill 1 once this week. Do not skip the "why it works" step; that step is the whole drill. For an essayist, the extraction drill (drill 2) is the best fit: pull ten Note-sized ideas out of a single essay you already wrote.

Lesson 3: Post structures and hooks

What Koe does. He keeps a small set of attention levers and says to use two or more per short post OPINION. Paraphrased: specific numbers; a pattern interrupt; a negative or warning frame; naming the group you are speaking to; naming the problem; stating the benefit; social proof; confident, un-hedged phrasing (add nuance in replies, not in the post); and short, rhythmic formatting where the first line is short and bullets lengthen. He describes common post shapes: an actionable list of principles, a "why this matters" post, a call-out of common mistakes DEMO, FROM HIS OWN TWEETS. For openers, he says strangers respond to "if you want X" or "if you're tired of Y" because the reader self-selects OPINION. He says hooks do much of the work: a ghostwriter friend reused the same body under a different hook and got a large gap in reach DEMO, ANECDOTAL. He also points to "topic plus hook" as most of growth, with relevance, awareness and effort as the test OPINION. Writers of any quality, he says, "remix": he calls writers DJs with ideas.

Why it works. A feed gives a post about a second. Hooks that name a reader or a problem make a quick yes/no decision easy. Structure reduces the cost of reading, which raises completion and sharing.

Do it. Build a "post shapes" sheet with five templates in your own words (list, mistake call-out, reframe, short story, question). Write them as blanks, not as Koe's wording. Keep one rule from his advice that suits your voice: cut hedges in the post, add nuance in a reply or in the essay.

A caution for essay writers: confident absolutes sit awkwardly with thoughtful, exploratory prose. You can be firm about the claim while the essay shows the doubt. If a stronger claim feels dishonest, soften the claim, not the clarity.

Lesson 4: Borrow validated topics, supply your own angle

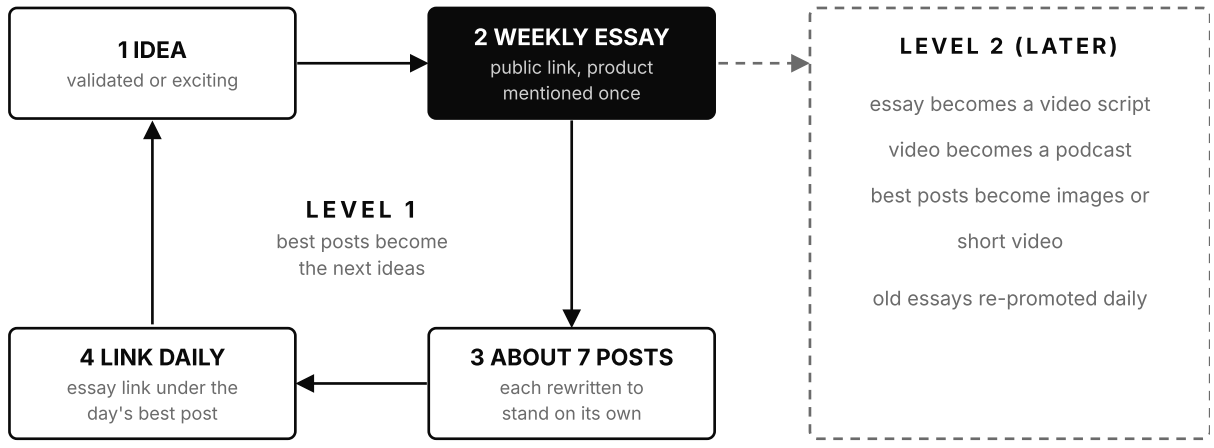
What Koe does. He argues nobody owns a topic. His example: a 2019 post with a "get ahead of most people" hook became a 2023 video that did very well, and several larger creators later used similar titles with different content DEMO, FIGURES HIS OWN: 1.7 MILLION VIEWS FOR HIS VERSION. His method: sort a few accounts' work by popularity, note the best 5-10 pieces, and recreate the topic with your angle OPINION. He proposes five angles for any idea: how a thinker you admire would put it; speak to your past self; redefine the term; state the common view and where you disagree; explain why it matters to an ordinary person OPINION. When growth stalls, he slots a validated-topic piece in to pull eyes toward more unusual ideas DEMO, HIS HABIT. He also describes a two-test topic filter: is it worth sharing to me, and is it packaged to grab attention? DEMO

Why it works. The audience is already searching for or reacting to certain promises. A familiar frame earns the click; your substance earns the follow. It is also less work than guessing.

Do it. For one idea you want to write about, find three outlier posts or titles on the same theme (use a platform's popular sort, or a creator's top posts). Write the packaging you would use, then check that the content underneath is honestly yours. The ethical line is borrowing a promise, not borrowing sentences.

Lesson 5: The content ecosystem, levels 1 and 2

What Koe does. In a paid post and several free ones, he describes one strong long piece feeding everything else, rather than separate content for each platform DEMO. He frames it as building a fictional universe: long form like the films, short posts like spin-offs, products like merchandise, with the goal of making a body of work someone can binge.



Start with one long-form home and one text platform. Add level 2 only when level 1 runs smoothly.

Figure 3. The level 1 content loop. Level 2 is added only once the loop is steady.

Level 1 (the base loop) DEMO:

1. An idea with potential becomes the weekly newsletter (public link, with a product link inside).
2. The newsletter is broken into spin-off posts.
3. One post per day links back to the newsletter.
4. Best-performing posts become new ideas.

One long-form home plus one writing-based short-form platform. That is all.

Level 2 (added only once level 1 runs smoothly) DEMO:

- The newsletter doubles as a video script.
- The video becomes a podcast.
- The video is embedded in the public newsletter page.
- Best posts turn into images or short-video scripts.
- Old newsletters get promoted daily.

He tells people not to create unique pieces per platform, but to make one strong piece and spread it OPINION. He also says the newsletter should be the “lead magnet and stealth sales page”: link it under posts instead of using a bare sign-up page (covered in Part 4).

Why it works. The cost of each new channel is spread over one piece of thinking. Short posts test which ideas land before you invest in long ones, and long pieces give short posts something deeper to point to.

Do it. Run level 1 only for eight weeks. Do not start level 2 until you can hit your weekly letter and daily Notes without strain. For Jono’s Journal, your level 1 loop is: essay (public) -> several standalone Notes -> one Note per day linking the essay or inviting a subscribe -> mine the best-performing Notes for next essay seeds. Level 2 is optional and probably last for a text-first writer; an audio version of the essay is a lighter candidate than video.

Lesson 6: The 2-hour daily schedule

What Koe does. He describes a repeatable daily budget DEMO, AS STATED:

Block	Time	Task
Newsletter	60 min, on five days	One day is outlining, another is publishing; the rest is drafting and editing
Short posts	30 min	Write the day's posts from the newsletter or the idea bank
Engagement and linking	30 min	Replies, DMs, link the newsletter under one post

Later he swaps days for filming and editing when adding video. He says maintenance mode runs year-round, and during a launch he focuses on the launch for one to two months DEMO. Elsewhere he says to do the writing first thing in a protected block, to quantify the task ("write 1,000 words" rather than "work on the newsletter"), and to use walks to collect ideas on the phone DEMO. A related claim: a smaller weekly time (4-6 hours) was enough for the system once built DEMO, SELF-REPORTED.

Why it works. A fixed budget removes the daily decision about whether to write. Quantified tasks and time boxes reduce deliberation. Putting engagement last stops it eating the creative block.

Do it. Adapt, don't copy. A reasonable essay version: 60 minutes on the weekly essay on four or five mornings, 20 minutes on Notes, 20 minutes on replies. Put the writing before email. Keep a one-line log of what you shipped each day.

Lesson 7: Traffic mechanisms: replies, quote posts, reposts, DMs

What Koe does. He says writing is about 20% of growth and traffic about 80% OPINION, and lists four manual mechanisms DEMO/OPINION:

Mechanism	Koe's method (paraphrased)	Substack equivalent
Replies	Reply to larger accounts with something interesting; talk about your own experience instead of saying "great post". A story opener ("I remember when...") is better than praise. He suggests 10-30 replies a day at the start, mixing small, medium and large accounts.	Comment on Notes and posts by writers slightly above you
Quote posts	Add a view to someone's post so their audience sees your take	Restack with a comment (Notes)
Reposts	Ask before posting: why would anyone share this? Write for sharing, and sometimes ask for a share after building rapport	Restacks by peers
Manual DMs	Genuine rapport, a few per day	Direct messages; email

His non-needy networking process, in seven steps DEMO, HE SAYS HE USED IT EARLY: pick someone you really want to talk to (near your size at first); send casual, honest praise that echoes their own post; show interest in their projects; be useful (send a resource that reminds you of them); optionally take a call or voice notes; keep sharing relevant things; then, only later, write something so good they would want to share it. Showing up in their replies first means the DM isn't cold. He says to spend about 30 minutes a day on this OPINION and says it is half a beginner's job OPINION. For zero-follower accounts, he lists three "catalyst" tactics: pay for help, join a tribe of same-size accounts, or trade value (for example, writing something for them) OPINION.

Why it works. A stranger's audience is the only place new readers exist for you in the first year. Genuine, specific engagement is what turns an unknown name into a familiar one.

Do it. Pick five writers on Substack within roughly 0.5-3x your size. For one week, leave one specific comment per day on their work (a detail you actually noticed). In week two, send one DM sharing something useful. Don't ask for anything.

Platform note: Koe's mechanisms were learned on X. Substack's graph works differently (Notes, restacks, recommendations, subscribers sharing posts). The principle (be useful in other people's rooms) transfers; the exact numbers (10-30 replies) do not. Test and measure on Substack.

Lesson 8: Remix, curation and crediting

What Koe does. He lists several ways to borrow reach without begging OPINION, WITH SOME DEMO:

- Write about someone's idea, tag them, and send it to them. He describes curating a newsletter section as "the best idea I saw this week", crediting people, then telling them.
- Build threads that compile top posts from several people and tag them.
- Interview creators, which he did first via a podcast to get guests DEMO.
- Write something that makes a larger account look good, such as an email sequence for them OPINION.

Why it works. People share what features them. Crediting is cheap, builds relationships, and signals that you read widely. Curation also keeps you producing when you lack a fresh idea, because the "idea" is the selection and the commentary.

Do it. Add a short "worth reading this week" section to one newsletter a month, with three links and a sentence of real commentary each, and notify the writers. Always quote briefly, link, and add your own thinking. Never reproduce someone's text wholesale.

Lesson 9: Tribes and masterminds

What Koe does. He advises finding 5-10 peers in the same space, commenting on each other's work, sharing it, and setting up a list plus a group chat so you can trade help
OPINION; HE SAYS HE DID SOMETHING SIMILAR WITH FRIENDS, WITH A MENTION THAT HE BEFRIENDED TWO CREATORS AT AROUND 15,000 FOLLOWERS
DEMO, ANECDOTAL. He distinguishes this from "engagement pods", saying a friend group chat swapping shares differs from a mechanical pod OPINION. He claims a 1,000-follower account with a strong network can out-earn a 50,000 account with none OPINION, UNSUPPORTED.

Why it works. Early on, peers are the most reachable audience, and reciprocal sharing introduces your work to people who already trust the sharer.

Do it. Ask four or five writers to form a group chat with a rule: share each other's best piece weekly with a real line about why it's good. If the chat turns into automatic reciprocal liking, stop; that is a pod, and readers and platforms tend to see through it.

Lesson 10: Short form builds, long form keeps

What Koe does. He says short posts bring attention and long posts bring trust: "short builds audience, long keeps it" OPINION. His layering: short = broad reach, medium (threads, carousels) = shows competence, long (newsletter) = superfans. He recommends one short-form platform and one long-form home OPINION and says to master one platform before spreading OPINION. He advises sending everyone to the newsletter, and says algorithms based on interests make follower count less important than the email list OPINION. He says to grow on the easier platform and funnel to harder ones: he grew on X and funnelled to YouTube DEMO. His reported growth: one thread grew into a video that reached 1.5 million views and added a large number of subscribers; then he made many more videos on the topic that worked DEMO, FIGURES HIS OWN. The moral he draws: growth comes in bursts, and you should double down after a hit.

Why it works. Attention that is brief is cheap to win but cheap to lose. Longer exposure produces habit and trust, which is what converts into email and purchases. Putting the owned list at the centre protects you from platform changes.

Do it. Write down where your next 1,000 subscribers will come from. If the answer is "more of the same", pick one platform to add or deepen. For you, Notes is the short-form home and email is the owned asset. Take a quarterly screenshot of the subscribers-by-source report and tally which behaviours moved it.

Lesson 11: Paid growth, platform risk and ethics (honest and caveated)

What Koe does. Koe is open that he uses paid growth, but with narrow, specific rules OPINION, WITH DEMO OF THE GENERAL PRACTICE:

- Pay mid-sized accounts to repost or reply to content that is genuinely good, not to run follower ads. He cited budgets of roughly $250-2,000 for around 30 reposts from accounts with 20,000-80,000 followers, and says a lead magnet should sit underneath OPINION, FIGURES FROM ONE PAID POST.
- Avoid shout-outs for follower growth and avoid ads that buy followers.
- Content quality retains the new followers; paid reach cannot rescue weak writing.
- In another letter he lists “bought” distribution (ads, sponsorships, paid shares) alongside “built” and “borrowed”, and says he prefers paid growth of this sort OPINION.
- He also lists “paying people who sell growth help” as a catalyst for tiny accounts OPINION.

Why this is risky. I am separating Koe’s view from the risks he does not dwell on. These are my cautions, not his:

1. **Disclosure.** Paid promotion that looks like an organic recommendation can breach advertising rules in many places (for example, the US FTC expects clear disclosure of paid endorsements). Check the rules where you and the promoter live.
2. **Platform terms.** Many platforms forbid purchased engagement or manipulation. Rules differ by platform and change. Read the current terms; I have not verified Substack’s.
3. **Audience fit.** A reader gained through a repost that sold them a “hot take” may not want a considered essay. Expect a lower open rate and more unsubscribes.
4. **Reputation.** Readers of a thoughtful publication may react badly if they find out.
5. **Survivorship.** Koe has a large base, a funnel to monetise paid followers, and tactics tuned to X. A small essay publication has no product ladder to pay back the spend.
6. **Opportunity cost.** Money spent on reposts could go to better-written pieces or to a collaborator’s time.

Do it. Treat paid growth as an experiment with a cap. If you try it, spend a small fixed amount once, on your single best evergreen piece, with clear disclosure, and measure cost per retained subscriber after 30 days. For an essay publication, the lower-risk equivalents are unpaid: peer swaps, recommendations from similar writers, and guest essays. Skip anything that buys followers or engagement.

Sample 7-day post plan (generic template)

Built around one weekly essay published on a fixed day. Seven standalone posts, one per day, each with its own hook. Substitute your own topics.

Day	Post type	Purpose	Link?
Day 1 (publish day)	Core claim in one sharp paragraph	State the essay’s main reframe	Yes, link the essay
Day 2	Common mistake call-out	Name what most people get wrong	Subscribe prompt in reply
Day 3	Short personal story (5-8 lines)	Humanise; show where the idea came from	No
Day 4	Curated pick	Credit someone and add your commentary; notify them	Their link
Day 5	Question to the audience	Learn objections and ideas; seeds for next essay	No
Day 6	List of 3-5 takeaways	Easy to save and share	Yes, essay link in reply
Day 7	Reflection or “what I changed my mind about”	Show thinking; set up next week’s topic	Preview

Rules: each post must make sense without the essay; rewrite, do not paste excerpts; link in one post per day at most; log which post got the most replies and saves.

EXERCISES (PART 3)

Exercise 3.1: Structure transplant (45 minutes). Save ten Notes or posts you admire. For each, write one line on why it worked. Choose three structures and write three of your own Notes from essay ideas. *Deliverable:* a one-page sheet of 10 structures with reasons, plus 3 drafted Notes.

Exercise 3.2: Extraction from one essay (30 minutes). Take your most-read Jono's Journal essay. Pull out ten standalone Note ideas (a claim, a mistake, a story, a question, a quote). Write the first lines only. *Deliverable:* 10 hooks in a list.

Exercise 3.3: Outlier scan (40 minutes). Find three writers slightly ahead of you. Sort their posts by most popular. List the 5 top topics and the repeating angles. Write what you would add. *Deliverable:* a table of topics, angle, your difference.

Exercise 3.4: Seven-day plan (60 minutes plus the week). Fill in the 7-day plan with the essay you publish next. Post for seven days. Record impressions or reactions, new subscribers by day. *Deliverable:* a log with the best and worst day and a guess why.

Exercise 3.5: Five-writer outreach (15 minutes a day for 10 days). Pick five writers. Follow the non-needy steps: five days of specific comments, then one useful DM each. *Deliverable:* a table: name, comment count, reply received, any collaboration.

Exercise 3.6: Schedule trial (one week). Run the 2-hour budget, adapted: 60 / 30 / 30 minutes. Note how much slipped and why. *Deliverable:* a schedule you will actually keep.

Checklist for each weekly cycle:

- ☐ One essay outlined by midweek
- ☐ Seven standalone Notes drafted
- ☐ One link-bearing Note per day, not more
- ☐ Five specific comments on peers' work
- ☐ One DM or note of thanks sent
- ☐ Review of best and worst performers on Friday

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 3)

1. **Does "write for beginners and keep it broad" fit a publication whose appeal is that it is thoughtful?** If your readers come for depth, a pain-first, broad hook may attract people who will never read a 2,000-word essay. What would you lose if your Notes got more reach but your open rate fell? Is there a version of "broad" that stays honest, such as a wide theme explored through narrow stories?
2. **Is more reach the goal, or more of the right readers?** Koe's numbers (12 million monthly impressions on one platform at one point, a few hundred thousand followers across others) come from a business where the audience buys products. If you have no product, what exactly is the value of an extra 1,000 readers who skim? What would you measure instead (reply rate, shares, paid conversion, a note from a reader)?
3. **Which of these tactics would you be comfortable explaining openly to a reader?** Replies and DMs are easy to defend. Paid reposts, curated threads that tag people to get a share, and confident absolutes you don't quite believe are harder. Where is your line, and does your answer change if the tactic worked for Koe but made your writing less honest?

RECAP (PART 3)

Koe's free-writing system is a daily, low-cost routine that sends strangers toward a weekly long-form piece. The pieces are: broad, pain-first short posts for beginners; drills that train structure and idea extraction; borrowed topics with your own angle; a simple level-1 loop (newsletter -> spin-off posts -> link back) before any level-2 repurposing; a two-hour daily budget; and hands-on traffic work through replies, restacks or quote posts, DMs, curation and a small tribe. Paid reposts exist in his toolkit but carry disclosure, platform, fit and reputation risks that a small essay publication should weigh carefully. Everything here is self-reported by someone with a large base and a product ladder, so adapt the principles, test small, and judge by whether the readers you gain are the readers you want.

PART 04

04

The Newsletter

Make one weekly essay the engine of everything else.

- → The newsletter is the lead magnet and a stealth sales page
- → The outline-first weekly workflow
- → Topic selection with reach, relevance and resonance
- → Hooks that show what most people get wrong
- → The three newsletter frameworks
- → Structure of the typical letter
- → P.S. and mid-letter promos, done honestly
- → Write standalone posts from a newsletter
- → Welcome email and lead magnet
- → Growth loops
- → Edit with AI critique, do not draft with AI

Introduction

In Koe's model, the newsletter is the centre. Short posts attract; the newsletter teaches, builds trust, and holds the offers. He says most of his sales came from long-form writing, and one old letter puts the figure at 95% DEMO/OPINION, SELF-REPORTED, FROM AROUND 2022. This part covers how he plans, writes and structures a weekly letter, how it works as a lead magnet and a stealth sales page, and how to use AI for critique rather than drafting.

Two honest limits. First, Koe's letters are persuasion pieces for a business: each is built to move a reader toward a next step. Your essays are not designed that way, and you may not want them to be. Second, his frameworks come from how-to and self-improvement writing. They suit practical pieces better than reflective ones. I flag where the fit is weak.

Lesson 1: The newsletter is the lead magnet and a stealth sales page

What Koe does. Instead of sending strangers to a bare "sign up" page, he links the actual newsletter (a public page) under his daily posts DEMO. The newsletter then plays two roles: a free sample that shows the reader what they will get (the lead magnet), and a soft sales page because at least one product link sits inside it DEMO, FROM A PAID POST. He says long form builds more trust than short form and that readers "cash in" that trust when he promotes something, so he avoids pushy selling OPINION. He also advises starting the list from day one OPINION, and says archived newsletters can serve as free lead magnets DEMO. A caution he gives himself: don't start a newsletter if you have no readers, no offer, and no way to get readers, unless you follow a system OPINION. The order he suggests: a source of audience, then an offer, then newsletter depth.

Why it works. A public letter proves value before asking for an email address. It also gives the reader a reason to subscribe that is specific rather than a promise.

Do it. Make your public essay page do the work: a clear subscribe prompt near the top, a short line about what the publication is, and one mention of what a subscriber gets that a visitor doesn't. Link essays, not your homepage, under Notes.

Lesson 2: The outline-first weekly workflow

What Koe does. He outlines at the start of the week, which gives a frame of reference for everything he reads and notices afterward DEMO. Through the week he adds ideas to the outline on his phone, often during walks, and writes the draft in a protected block DEMO. Another variant: capture ideas on one day, outline another, publish on another DEMO. He builds around five steps: pick a topic that already performs, dump ideas, make an outline page, write a draft page, then edit DEMO. His outline contains elements such as hook and title brainstorms, linked notes, quotes and evidence, questions and objections, pain amplification, goal, personal experience, a fresh angle, actionable steps, a one-sentence big idea, and concepts DEMO. His summary: you learn to organise thoughts persuasively, not to write persuasively DEMO. He also says writer's block is usually missing ideas, not missing words OPINION. He says to write about one topic per week because the mind collects around a single theme DEMO.

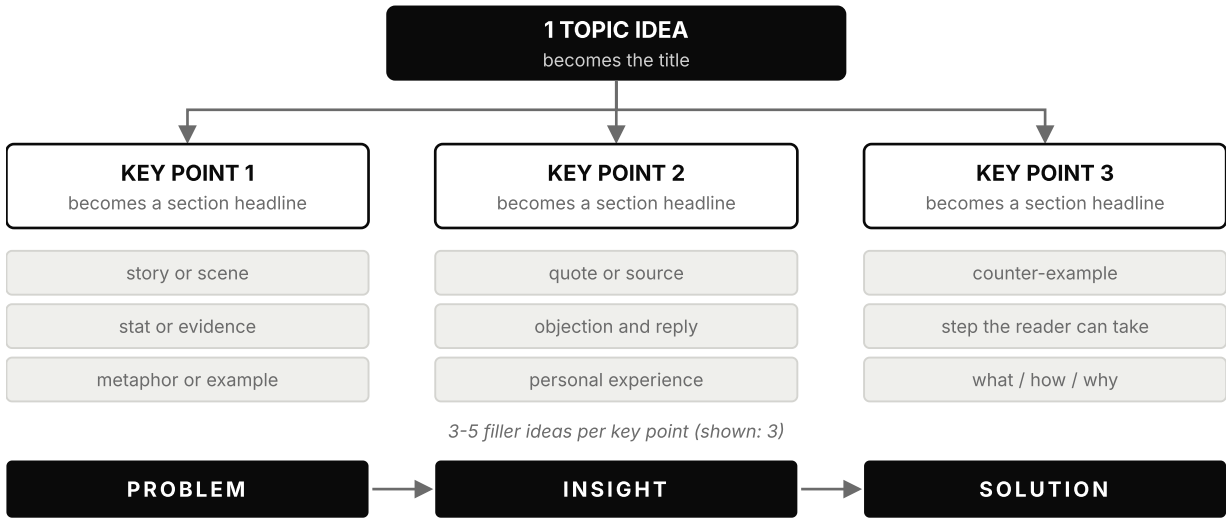


Figure 4. Anatomy of a long-form piece: one topic, three or more key points, and filler ideas under each.

Why it works. Outlining first separates deciding what to say from finding words for it. Because ideas can be added at any time, drafting becomes assembly rather than invention.

Do it. On a fixed day, open a blank outline with the headings above (adapted below). Add to it whenever an idea arrives. Draft only when at least three key points and one story are in the outline.

SAMPLE WEEKLY NEWSLETTER OUTLINE TEMPLATE

Use this as a fill-in sheet. It is generic, built from the elements Koe describes, and not his text.

```
WEEK OF: ______      PUBLISH DAY: ______

1. TOPIC (one line): ______
   Reach / Relevance / Resonance score (1-5 each): __ __ __
   Performance vs excitement (circle): high-perf / high-excitement / both

2. WORKING TITLES (write 10, pick 1): ______

3. THE HOOK (200-500 words)
   - What most people get wrong: ______
   - Where I got it wrong / the story: ______
   - Promise of the piece: ______

4. KEY POINTS (3 for an essay, more for a list)
   Point A: claim / example / quote / objection
   Point B: claim / example / quote / objection
   Point C: claim / example / quote / objection

5. FILLER: 3-5 notes per point (story, stat, metaphor, scene, counter-example)

6. THE TURN: the one-sentence big idea: ______

7. ACTION OR QUESTION (what the reader can do or ask themselves): ______

8. PROMO (one): mid-letter ____ / P.S. ____ (or none this week)

9. STANDALONE NOTES TO DERIVE (7): ______

10. AI CRITIQUE PASS DONE? hook / structure / density / clarity
```

Time check. Day 1: pick topic and outline. Days 2-3: gather. Days 3-4: draft. Day 5: edit and critique. Day 6: publish. Day 7: review numbers.

Lesson 3: Topic selection with reach, relevance and resonance

What Koe does. In a paid piece on long-form writing, he lists three tests for a topic: reach (will it travel beyond people who already know you), relevance (does it matter to your readers' goals), and resonance (does it hit a felt need) OPINION. He also balances "performance" (it has done well elsewhere) against "excitement" (you care about it), saying the best topics sit where the two overlap DEMO, AS A STATED PROCESS. He keeps a short list of 5-10 candidate topics at any time DEMO. Sources, in his words as I read them: a content map, your own top-performing posts, the top posts of favourite accounts, and idea-dense old books or curated blogs DEMO. A more specific method: find three to five channels, sort by popularity, note the top titles, and fit your idea to one of the angles DEMO. He notes titles from video transfer to newsletter headlines DEMO.

Why it works. The overlap rule guards against two failures: writing only what you like and no one reads, or writing only what sells and running out of energy.

Do it. Score each of your next five topics on the three Rs, then add a "performance" and "excitement" score. Write the one that scores high on both. If excitement is high and performance low, write it anyway but give it a stronger hook and expect slower pickup.

For Jono's Journal, "performance" can be read from your own Notes: topics where the Note drew replies are market-tested.

Lesson 4: Hooks that show what most people get wrong

What Koe does. His hook advice for long-form is to open by showing what most people get wrong, through a personal story or a direct statement, and then add a one-line big idea, an example, a statistic or a quote. The hook runs about 200-500 words and sets up the promise of the piece OPINION, FROM A PAID POST. Hook types he uses across letters (my pattern-spotting across many letters):

Hook type	Shape
Wrong-way-to-do-it	State the common behaviour, then flip it
Confession	A concrete failure or low point, then the lesson
Reader call-out	"Tell me if any of these sound like you" followed by recognisable scenes
Contrarian claim	Take a popular belief, partly agree, then change the premise
Plea or stakes	A short, direct appeal followed by why it matters
Definition then flip	Quote a definition, then argue the opposite framing

He also notes that newsletter openings usually start with a personal problem and how he got past it, as proof DEMO. Another habit: a short promise paragraph or preview near the top ("in this letter"), and headings written as claims rather than topic labels [pattern across many letters].

Why it works. Readers decide in the first paragraph whether the piece is about them. Showing a wrong-but-common view creates a gap the reader wants closed.

Do it. Write the hook last. Draft three: one wrong-way, one confession, one call-out. Pick the one that sounds most like you. Test: could a stranger tell, from the first 100 words, who it is for and what changes?

Lesson 5: The three newsletter frameworks

What Koe does. He gives three frameworks, graded by difficulty DEMO/OPINION, FROM A PAID GUIDE:

Framework	Level	Parts	Best for
Pain & Process	Beginner	Open with the reader's problem, then give the steps to fix it, then (optionally) link an offer	Practical pieces, first newsletters

Framework	Level	Parts	Best for
Pain, Concept, Process	Intermediate	Problem, then a deeper concept that reframes it (the novelty), then the steps	Pieces with an idea behind the method
Perspective, Advantage, Gamify	Advanced	The common view, then a better view and why it is an advantage, then a step-by-step "game" using ideas from flow psychology (clear goals, feedback, rising challenge)	Pieces that change how someone sees something and give them a structured way to act

Other templates he mentions: problem-amplify-solution, with a story and testimony added for sales copy; and a big idea, problem, amplify, solution layout with two sections DEMO. He suggests collecting five to ten frameworks, writing the same idea in several, then noticing patterns and bending the rules OPINION. A structural habit: state the conclusion first, give three or more arguments, then support each DEMO, PYRAMID PRINCIPLE.

Why it works. A framework removes the question of what comes next and keeps the reader moving from "this is me" to "here is what to do".

Do it. Write one piece in each of the three frameworks over three weeks, then compare. Pain & Process for a practical piece, Pain-Concept-Process for something with a named idea, Perspective-Advantage-Gamify when you want to challenge a common view and leave the reader with a way to test it.

Fit for essays. These are built for pieces that end in action. A personal or reflective essay may have no process. You can still use the shape lightly: open with a tension, introduce a concept that reframes it, end on a question or a small experiment rather than a how-to.

Lesson 6: Structure of the typical letter

What Koe does. Looking across many free letters, the shape is steady (my synthesis; individual letters vary):

1. A title that is a claim or a promise, often with a number or a bracketed twist.
2. A short opener: story, claim, confession or call-out.
3. A promise or preview ("in this letter you will see…").
4. Numbered sections, with headings written as claims, short paragraphs and many one-sentence lines.
5. A named idea or model in nearly every letter, with a metaphor from another domain (gym, games, food).
6. A recap or a practical exercise.
7. A sign-off and sometimes a P.S.
8. In older letters, a "what happened this week" footer.

He also reports that he walks the reader up an awareness ladder: state the problem, show its impact, give the solution, and place relevant products along the way DEMO. Letters range from about 1,200 to 7,000 words; recent ones are shorter with sharper hooks (my pattern).

Why it works. Predictable structure reduces reading effort. A named model makes the letter easy to remember and to quote.

Do it. Write a "house structure" in 8 lines. Keep it, with room to break it.

Lesson 7: P.S. and mid-letter promos, done honestly

What Koe does. His promo placement, observed across letters:

- A short note near the top for a time-bound launch (cohort, challenge, workshop), sometimes labelled openly as self-promotion and skippable DEMO.
- A mid-letter reminder box, often at a natural break DEMO.
- A P.S. at the end that repeats the offer, often with a deadline or a reader-only price DEMO.
- Inline mentions placed where the related claim appears DEMO.

- A footer “what happened this week” block with new videos, community posts and a low-price offer for readers (older letters; for example $5 reader pricing) DEMO.
- A “how I can help” list at the end, ordered by what the reader might want.

He states plainly when promo is done (“sales promo done”), and says his free letters do the thinking while the offers sit in set places DEMO. He argues that if you teach well and promote at a steady cadence, selling feels natural. He also says to promote once a day in some form and to include at least one product mention in every newsletter OPINION.

Why it works. Readers know where promotions appear, so the teaching is not interrupted. Deadlines and price rises create a reason to act now.

Do it. Decide your slots in advance: one mid-letter and one P.S., used only when you have something worth offering. Label them. Keep them to two or three sentences.

For an essayist without a product. The offer can be a paid subscription, a recommendation of another writer, or a one-line request to forward the essay. The principle that transfers is: put asks in the same places each time, name them, and keep them brief.

Lesson 8: Write standalone posts from a newsletter

What Koe does. In his ecosystem posts, he says not to paste excerpts. Instead, rewrite each idea so it stands alone with its own hook, aiming for about seven posts per weekly newsletter, one for each day to link under DEMO, FROM A PAID POST. Other details: tweets that performed become the seed of the next newsletter, and the newsletter is also mined for tweets, carousels and scripts DEMO. His cycle: validate on short form, expand to long form, then break the long form back into short pieces. He also reports using AI to pull post ideas from an old newsletter DEMO, while writing the final posts himself.

Why it works. A post that depends on the letter fails for people who haven’t read it. A standalone post earns its own attention and then sends a fraction to the source.

Do it. After drafting, list seven separate claims from the essay. For each, write a hook, one body, and a close that doesn’t need the essay. Schedule them across the week.

Lesson 9: Welcome email and lead magnet

What Koe does. He recommends a welcome email that says what you cover, your vision and what to expect, then two or three story or problem emails, then, only later, a sales sequence OPINION, FROM AN OLDER LETTER. His lead-magnet advice DEMO/OPINION:

- Make it beginner-level and action-oriented.
- A swipe file, template, checklist, short ebook, or a repurposed best newsletter works.
- A free product has three jobs: it creates customers, it centralises your authority (so plug it often), and it sells the next product (pitch at the end while leads are warm).
- When a topic keeps working, make a free product or pinned thread containing nearly everything you know about it, so you stop repeating yourself DEMO.
- Funnel logic: broad content, then a specific free product, then a paid product, then more free products.
- Offer a qualifying question or two in the sign-up or follow-up (for example, “what is your biggest struggle with X?”) because it filters and warms the lead OPINION.

Why it works. The first emails set expectations and show what the list is for. A well-chosen free item gives a reason to sign up now and a way to check the fit.

Do it. Write a three-email welcome sequence: (1) what this publication is, who it is for, and where to start; (2) your most useful essay, with one sentence on why; (3) a single question asking what they are struggling with. Set the first as Substack’s welcome email. A simple lead magnet for Jono’s Journal could be a short reading list or a “start here” page of your five best essays, organised by theme.

Lesson 10: Growth loops

What Koe does. The loops he describes, combined:

1. **Post to letter to post.** Posts attract; the letter retains; the best-performing letter ideas return as posts, and the best posts become the next letter DEMO.
2. **Letter to offer to proof to letter.** Offers produce results and testimonials, which become material for letters [pattern].
3. **Serial hooks.** Letters often promise the next topic (“next week I’ll show…”) or leave an open loop, bringing readers back [pattern across many letters].
4. **Internal linking.** Constant links to older letters build depth and keep readers in the archive [pattern].
5. **Reader asks.** A closing request to reply, share or forward, sometimes as a joke line [pattern].
6. **Reader feedback.** Asking audiences what they struggle with produces topics DEMO.
7. **Cross-promotion.** Guest teachers or collaborators with a proven result, used for workshops DEMO.

Why it works. Each loop uses an output as the next input, so effort compounds instead of resetting weekly.

Do it. Pick two loops for the next quarter: one internal (serial hooks plus links to older essays) and one external (a collaboration or recommendation swap). Track what each adds.

Lesson 11: Edit with AI critique, do not draft with AI

What Koe does. His position, repeated in several places: AI is for thinking and critique, not for writing the final text DEMO/OPINION.

- All his letters are hand-written; AI helps with research and idea prompts DEMO.
- He tried prompts “the size of a mini course” and found only about one output in a hundred usable DEMO, 2025.
- A “thought partner” method: before writing, tell the AI the topic, and have it interview you one question at a time, pushing past generic answers until you produce several breakthroughs and a named concept for each. The result becomes an outline DEMO, AS HE DESCRIBES IT. Rules he builds in: no compliments, one question at a time, challenge vague claims, give unnamed ideas a name.
- AI to dissect great writing (macro and micro structure) so you learn from it, rather than to write for you DEMO.
- Running drafts through AI for critique of the hook and idea density, and a final pass for clarity, not grammar DEMO.
- AI as a source of structure options, directions and facts, but not of opinions DEMO.
- A commenter’s test of an AI-made article from one of his outlines still sounded generic DEMO, SECONDHAND.

Why it works. A critic that asks questions finds gaps you are too close to see, while the voice, which is what readers come for, stays yours.

Do it. After the first full draft, run three critique passes in separate chats, and make the edits yourself:

1. *Hook:* “Where would a reader stop? What is unclear in the first 300 words?”
2. *Structure:* “Summarise each section in one line. Where does the argument wobble?”
3. *Density:* “Which paragraphs repeat a point or lack a concrete example?”

Never paste the AI’s rewrite. Ask for questions and observations, then write your own sentence. Disclose AI help in a way you are comfortable with if readers would care. Because your readers come for your thinking, treat this boundary as part of the brand.

EXERCISES (PART 4)

Exercise 4.1: Topic scoring (30 minutes). List ten possible essay topics. Score reach, relevance, resonance, performance and excitement from 1 to 5. Choose the top three. *Deliverable:* a scored table and your next three essay topics.

Exercise 4.2: Three hooks (30 minutes). For one of those topics, write a wrong-way hook, a confession hook and a call-out hook, each 150-300 words. Read them aloud. *Deliverable:* three hooks and a note on which one you would publish and why.

Exercise 4.3: Framework trial (3 weeks). Draft one essay in each of the three frameworks, outline only if short on time. Compare ease, clarity, and reader response. *Deliverable:* a one-paragraph verdict on which fits your voice.

Exercise 4.4: Outline-first week (7 days). Run the weekly template: outline on day 1, add ideas for three days, draft on days 4 and 5, publish day 6. *Deliverable:* the filled template and a note of what you cut.

Exercise 4.5: Seven Notes from one essay (45 minutes). Take a published essay. Write seven standalone Notes, each with a hook, so that none needs the essay to make sense. *Deliverable:* seven Notes scheduled across a week.

Exercise 4.6: Welcome sequence (60 minutes). Write the three welcome emails described in Lesson 9, plus a "start here" list of five essays. *Deliverable:* three emails and a start-here page.

Exercise 4.7: AI critique pass (45 minutes). Run a recent draft through the three critique prompts above (write your own). Make edits by hand. *Deliverable:* a before/after of the first 300 words and a list of what the AI caught.

Checklist before publishing:

- ☐ Topic scored and chosen
- ☐ Title is a claim or promise
- ☐ Hook shows what most people get wrong (or equivalent)
- ☐ Framework chosen, or consciously broken
- ☐ One promo slot filled or deliberately empty
- ☐ Seven standalone Notes drafted
- ☐ Critique passes done; final wording is mine
- ☐ Next week's teaser or open loop included

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 4)

1. **Are your essays meant to persuade, or to explore?** Koe's frameworks assume the reader should end up doing something. If an essay's value is that it leaves a question open, what would a "process" step add, and what would it cost? Can you keep the hook and structure ideas without turning every essay into a how-to?
2. **Does a weekly deadline help your thinking, or flatten it?** Koe has written nearly every week for years and says the discipline built his skill, but he also admits to slumps, scrapped drafts and letters that were less practical. What is the evidence, in your own archive, that your best essays come out of a rhythm rather than out of waiting? Would every second week serve readers better?
3. **If the newsletter is a "stealth sales page", what is it selling in your case?** Koe's letters lead to courses, challenges and software. If you have none, what do you want the reader to do after reading: subscribe to a paid tier, share, buy a future book, or simply think differently? Is that goal honest enough to say aloud, and does the structure of your letters serve it?

RECAP (PART 4)

Koe's newsletter is the hub: a public, weekly piece that works as both lead magnet and soft sales page, planned by outlining early in the week and filling the outline through the days. Topics are chosen where reach, relevance and resonance overlap with something he cares about. Hooks open by showing what most people get wrong. Three frameworks (Pain & Process, Pain-Concept-Process, Perspective-Advantage-Gamify) give a repeatable spine, and promo sits in fixed, honest slots such as a mid-letter reminder and the P.S. Each letter is mined for about seven standalone posts, a welcome sequence and free item convert visitors to subscribers, and loops of serial hooks, internal links and reader questions keep people returning. AI is used for interviewing, structure analysis and critique, while the words stay human. Most of this is self-reported and tuned for practical, product-linked writing, so keep what strengthens your essays and drop what turns them into marketing.

PART 05

05

The Offer and the Ladder

Decide what people can pay you for, and in what order.

- → The ladder, and why the order matters
- → The micro service
- → The micro product
- → The qualification form
- → The manual outreach conversation
- → The 3-point marketing strategy
- → The six marketing-strategy components
- → The mechanism, and how to name it
- → Lead magnets
- → Price and scarcity events
- → Making the offer legible inside an essay-led newsletter
- → Offer worksheet (printable)

Before you begin: how to read the evidence

Everything below comes from Koe's own letters. Tags used throughout:

- DEMO means he says he did it, and often gives numbers. These are self-reported, unaudited, and subject to survivorship bias: we hear about the launches that worked, from someone with a very large audience.
- OPINION means he asserts it as advice, without proof that it generalizes.

Income figures in his letters (a launch near $700K, "$1 per follower", five clients equals $5K) describe his circumstances. They are not forecasts for a Substack writer with thousands of subscribers. Treat them as shapes of arithmetic, not promises. Some tactics he uses are aggressive (hard scarcity, paid reposts, heavy self-promotion). Where that matters, this playbook flags it and recommends the truthful version.

Intro

Koe's money model is simple to state. Free writing attracts people. A newsletter builds trust. An offer converts a small percentage of them. The offers are stacked in a deliberate order, cheap and personal at the bottom, repeatable and scalable at the top. Part 5 covers the offers and the order. Part 6 covers building the product. Part 7 covers selling it.

The most useful thing for Jono to hold in mind: Koe separates **content** from **product**. Content covers the what and the why, for people at point A. The product covers the how, the streamlined route from A to B OPINION. An essay-led writer already produces the first half. The ladder is about the second half.

Lesson 1: The ladder, and why the order matters

What Koe does. Across many letters from 2022 to 2026, he describes the same sequence with small variations:

1. Free content on one short-form platform and one long-form home (the newsletter).
2. A lead magnet or free guide that deepens trust.
3. A **micro service**: a handful of paid one-to-one sessions, priced around the high hundreds to low thousands. Sometimes alongside a **micro product** priced around $10 to $20.
4. A **cohort**: a time-boxed group program with a start date, calls, and a community.
5. A **standalone course** spun out of the cohort, cheaper, evergreen, upsells to the next cohort.
6. A **community**, last, once the audience is big enough to keep it alive.
7. Software or a book, after the earlier steps have produced cash and customer knowledge.

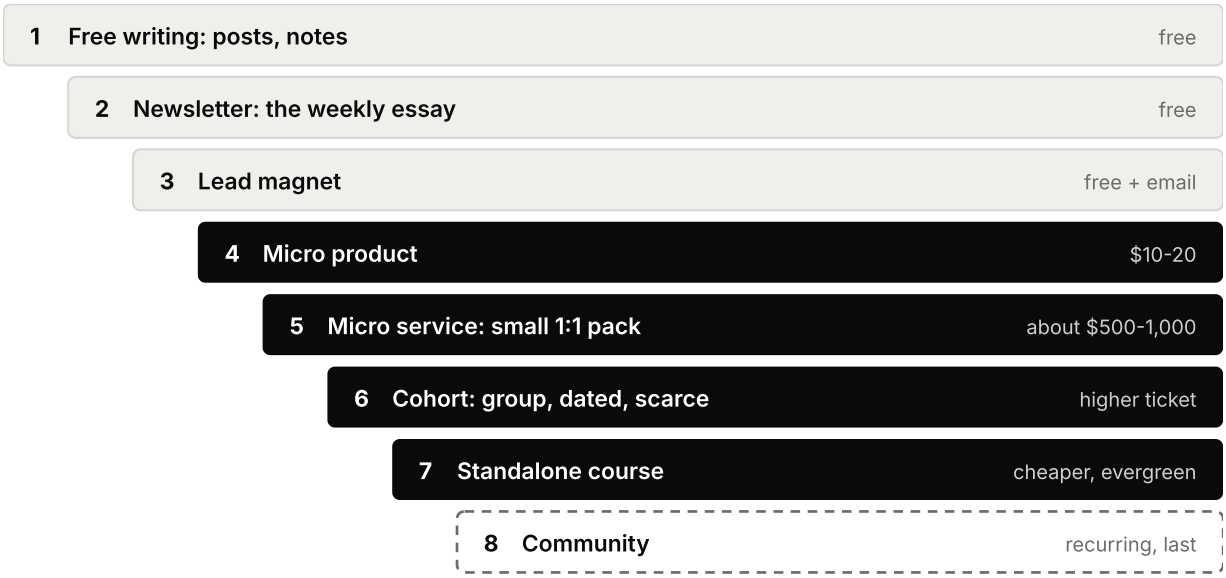


Figure 5. The ladder: free rungs build trust, paid rungs are added one at a time.

In the 2025 mega guide for paid subscribers he recommends cohort first (higher price, natural scarcity, repeatable three to five times a year, can be pre-sold and built week by week), then the course, then the community, spending roughly six to twelve months on each stage OPINION. He says he started his community at around 50K followers while growing about 5K a month DEMO. Elsewhere he calls community a slow grind and says he would have run a cohort sooner than he did.

His own history roughly matches: freelance web design, a few cheap information products, a planner, consulting, a community, a writing course, cohorts, a book, and eventually software DEMO. His revenue figures run from about $10K in a first product year to six or seven figures later. Treat them as his trajectory with a large audience and years of compounding.

One caution. In one letter he says he used to recommend service-first, but now tells people without real skills to improve themselves, document it, and productize DEMO OF A CHANGED VIEW. He holds two versions of the ladder, and you can pick the one that fits your situation.

Why it works.

- Each rung teaches you something the next rung needs. One-to-one calls teach you what people actually struggle with. A cohort teaches you the order of the curriculum. A course is that curriculum frozen.
- Higher prices need fewer customers, so you can start with a small audience.
- Scarcity (a start date, a cohort size) is natural in a cohort and artificial in an evergreen course.

Koe's reasoning for the order, laid out.

Rung	Why it sits here	Risk if you skip the order
Service (1:1)	Highest price per buyer, needs no audience, reveals which results are real	You build a course for a problem nobody confirmed
Cohort	Higher price, natural deadline, can be sold before it exists, repeatable a few times a year	Without calls and a start date, completion and urgency both fall
Standalone course	Reuses the cohort's recorded material and testimonials; cheaper, so it reaches people who cannot join live; upsells to the next cohort	A cheap course first has no proof and no tested sequence
Community	Needs a large, growing audience to stay lively; later products can be bundled in as bonuses	An empty community teaches readers that your offers are quiet

He also sketches a sample price ladder, roughly an ebook in the high twenties, a course around $150, a cohort near $400 OPINION, ILLUSTRATIVE. Treat those as relative spacing (each rung several times the one below), not as prices for Jono's Journal.

A second reading of the same evidence: much of it is the experience of a seller with an audience in the hundreds of thousands. A writer with thousands of subscribers should expect each step to bring in smaller numbers, and should judge a rung by what it teaches before judging it by what it earns.

Do it.

- Draw your ladder on one page with four boxes: free, micro (under $25), core (about $100 to $400), premium (over $500 or recurring).
- Mark which box you are filling first. Only one.
- Write the sentence that links each rung to the next. If you cannot say why a buyer of rung two would want rung three, the ladder is a list, not a ladder.

Lesson 2: The micro service

What Koe does. The recurring “minimum viable offer” is one of two things: a single-skill service, or a pack of four weekly one-to-one sessions, priced between roughly $500 and $1,000, sometimes more DEMO/OPINION. He sells it by direct message plus a questionnaire, with no sales page and often a payment link as the whole “store”. The structure is:

- A named process the person will work through, with a defined point A and point B.
- Four sessions, each with homework.
- A session shape that repeats: review last week’s tasks, work through the live blockers, set next steps.
- Onboarding questions before session one.

His math for why a service comes before a course: it is easier to make one $1,000 sale than ten $100 sales, you do not need an audience for a course yet, and you do not yet know what gets results DEMO/OPINION. He suggests starting near $500, moving to $1,000 after a few clients, and later to $2,500 or more as your results and specificity improve. He warns against jumping to $5K coaching without a system of your own.

The part most relevant to the playbook: the sessions generate the curriculum. Notes, worksheets, and dashboards from the calls become the product later. His phrasing is roughly that coaching notes become your course.

His illustrative funnel math OPINION, NOT VERIFIED: a few thousand impressions, thirty to forty questionnaire completions, twenty to thirty conversations, around five buyers, at one to two hours a day.

Why it works. It converts the least-known thing (what results people actually get) into data before you build anything. It is also fast: no page, no platform, one payment link.

Do it.

1. Write the offer in four lines: who it is for, point A, point B, the timeframe.
2. Outline four sessions, one theme each, with one homework task each.
3. Choose a price you would be comfortable defending if the buyer asked what they get.
4. Decide how many clients you can serve honestly. Cap it at that number.

Honesty check. A paid-for outcome promise must be deliverable. “Four sessions to a clear essay outline” is deliverable. “Four sessions to a full-time writing income” is not. Koe’s own rule of thumb that fits here: a gap between the glamour of the promise and the reality of the delivery is how a pitch tips into manipulation OPINION, FROM HIS LETTER ON OFFER “LOOKS AND DEPTH”. Keep that gap small.

Lesson 3: The micro product

What Koe does. Alongside or instead of the service, he suggests a very small digital product: a guide, template, short ebook, or training recording at roughly $10 to $20, built in under a week from something you already have OPINION/DEMO. His examples include a founder who sold his own old resume as a $10 template and made roughly $1K quickly, a good post expanded into a short guide, or a recorded 30 to 60 minute training. He suggests that if conversion is above about 2.5 percent at that price, it is worth building the fuller version.

He also says he wrote his first ebook at 140 followers and had about $3,000 in sales by 500 followers DEMO. Elsewhere he gives a more modest early picture: around $3,000 a month with 300 followers while still freelancing. These are his reports.

He also warns that at a small audience size a $19 product needs many buyers to matter, which is why he often ranks the service above it for people just starting OPINION.

Why it works. A micro product is a cheap test of whether your angle sells, and it gives the first buyers a way to say yes with low risk. It can funnel into the service: the product is the first step, the service is the guided version.

Do it.

- Pick the one existing asset (an essay series, a reading list with commentary, a worksheet) that already helped readers.
- Package it as a single file with a one-page landing page.
- Treat it as a demand test, not a revenue plan.

Lesson 4: The qualification form

What Koe does. Instead of a calendar link, he puts a short form in the bio, at the end of newsletters, and under posts DEMO. It asks about the person's goal, current state, target state, biggest struggle (multiple choice, which he stresses), how serious they are on a scale, and whether they are ready to invest. He lists three jobs for the form: it filters tire-kickers, it makes the person articulate their pain (which raises their own awareness of it), and it lowers pressure because nobody is on the phone yet.

Why it works. It gives you the language of your audience in their own words, which becomes headline and bullet material later. It turns a vague "interested" into a structured lead. And it respects the person's time.

Do it. Build a form with these slots, in your own wording:

1. What are you trying to achieve in the next 30 to 90 days?
2. Where are you now, specifically?
3. What is the main thing in the way (offer four to six choices plus "other")?
4. What have you already tried?
5. How serious is this for you, 1 to 10?
6. A plain statement that the offer is paid, so nobody is surprised.

Read every response. After twenty, tally the choices on question three. That tally tells you what your offer should be about.

Lesson 5: The manual outreach conversation

What Koe does. He describes a gentle DM sequence for people who fill the form or engage with you DEMO/OPINION:

1. **Open from their interest.** Pick up where their form answer or their comment left off. Ask about progress or their goal.
2. **Give one useful, non-obvious tip.** Not a generic one. Something that shows you can help.
3. **Mention the offer lightly,** including the price once the conversation is warm.
4. **Follow up once after two or three days** with something useful, like a link.
5. **One last nudge about a week later, then let it go.**

He also advises messaging only warm people and gives volume math: around thirty conversations per week, with a conversion needing to be under one percent yes for the numbers to work OPINION. A related idea is to speak to five to ten people a week and ask what they want to change DEMO.

Why it works. It is a conversation that behaves like help. The follow-up cadence is bounded, so it does not become pestering.

Do it. Write your own three templates and keep them short:

> *Opener: “Saw your answer about [their struggle]. Where are you with it right now?” Value: “One thing that helped me/people I’ve worked with: [specific tip].” Soft offer: “If you want a structured way through it, I run [offer]. No pressure, just wanted you to know it exists.”*

Ethical notes. Do not message people who did not engage. Do not fake scarcity in a DM. Stop after the second follow-up. If it is not a fit, say so and mean it.

Lesson 6: The 3-point marketing strategy

What Koe does. He reduces all marketing to three questions that every post, page, and email should answer OPINION/DEMO, FROM THE LAUNCHPAD COURSE AND “PURPOSE & PROFIT”:

1. **Who** can you help most? (Usually someone one or two steps behind you, often your past self.)
2. **What** can you help them achieve? (A specific outcome.)
3. **Why** should they care? (The pain of staying put and the benefit of moving.)

In the longer five-question version, he adds **where** they want to be (specific, concrete, such as a small measurable change) and **when** they will get results (a timeframe forces clarity). He also asks you to guess the audience’s awareness level (unaware, problem aware, solution aware, product aware, most aware) and write for the majority level.

His claim that “you are the niche” means your point A to point B story is the brand, not a topic category.

Why it works. It is a checklist short enough to use on a single post. The “why care” question catches the usual failure, which is describing the product instead of the reader’s problem.

Do it. Tape the three questions above your desk. Before publishing anything with a call to action, answer them in one sentence each. If you cannot, it is not ready.

Lesson 7: The six marketing-strategy components

What Koe does. In the 2025 mega guide he lists six components to decide before writing the product OPINION WITH DEMO FLAVOR. The order matters: marketing first, then the product built to deliver the promise.

#	Component	What it is	Jono’s Journal example (illustrative)
1	**Angle**	A route to a core desire (status, freedom from fear, skill, acceptance, enjoyment)	“Write the essay you keep postponing” (skill and fear)
2	**Clear, believable goal**	One or two steps ahead, with a number and a time	“A finished 1,200-word essay in 14 days”
3	**Transformation**	Before/after, not a feature list	From “I have notes and no essays” to “I publish weekly without dread”
4	**Bonuses**	Templates, checklists, a call, a training; also useful as launch incentives	An editing checklist, a hook swipe file
5	**Pricing**	Impulse-buy range for a first product, under about $225, commonly $100 to $150; beginners lower	$79 to $149 for a cohort or short course
6	**Risk reversal**	Guarantee, payment plan, social proof, tied to the goal	“Finish the essay or join the next cohort free”

His own goal statements fit the pattern: a stated number of days for a stated result DEMO. A worked example of risk reversal he uses elsewhere is a precise end result with a refund attached, as in a “dates in days” style promise. The principle is specificity, not that exact wording.

Why it works. Each component removes one reason to say no: unclear benefit, doubt it works, high price, fear of loss.

Do it. Fill the worksheet at the end of this part. Do not skip the guarantee. If you cannot guarantee the result, guarantee the process (attendance, deliverables, a refund window) and say plainly what you are guaranteeing.

Honesty check. A guarantee is a promise. Offer only one you will honor without argument. Do not stack made-up bonuses with inflated "values".

Lesson 8: The mechanism, and how to name it

What Koe does. He treats the mechanism as the unique system or process that sits between point A and point B and says systems sell OPINION. His build sequence DEMO:

1. List the steps you actually take to get the result.
2. Run them yourself for one or two weeks and refine.
3. Turn them into a documented process, which he also converts into an AI template.
4. Give it a memorable name: draft about five, sleep on it, pick one.

He gives name examples from his own work, such as three-part frameworks and numbered models like a content ecosystem or a short-workday label. In one prompt for paid subscribers, he asks the AI interviewer to push you to name unnamed processes by hunting for contrasts, paradoxes, and distinctive labels DEMO.

Why it works. A name makes an idea portable. Readers can repeat it, and a named method is easier to distinguish from the dozens of generic courses on the same subject. For an essay writer, naming is already the core craft.

Do it.

1. Write your steps for turning a rough idea into a finished essay, as if for a new colleague.
2. Run them on your next three essays. Cut the steps you skip.
3. Write five names. Test each against two rules: can a stranger guess what it does, and can you say it in under five syllables?
4. Use the name consistently in free essays so the audience already knows it when the product appears.

Lesson 9: Lead magnets

What Koe does. He treats a lead magnet as the first "niche" of the brand DEMO: a beginner-level, action-oriented free asset (swipe file, template, checklist, short ebook, a repackaged best newsletter) offered repeatedly. He claims eight to ten tested over time, and one planner lead magnet drew tens of thousands of downloads DEMO, SELF-REPORTED. He also says to turn the topic that keeps working into a single free asset containing almost everything you know about it, so you stop repeating yourself OPINION. In his later work the newsletter itself is the lead magnet: link it under posts instead of using a bare opt-in page, and place a product mention inside it.

Why it works. It qualifies readers by interest, builds authority, and frees later free essays to go deeper, because the basics live in the asset.

Do it. For Jono's Journal, candidates: "the essays that changed readers' minds most" as a short guide, a one-page essay-outline template, or a "first 500 words" hook checklist. Pick the one that matches your first offer's topic.

Lesson 10: Price and scarcity events

What Koe does. He anchors the first product at the impulse range, commonly $100 to $150, rising with each cohort DEMO/OPINION. One cohort sold at $150 for four calls over two weeks, and he reports a major month of revenue from it, after about four years of audience building DEMO, VERY SPECIFIC TO HIS SCALE. He prefers not to charge thousands for early cohorts. Scarcity devices he uses:

- A close date for enrollment.
- A price that rises on a stated date (pre-launch, early-bird, or "price doubles on the start date").

- Bonuses that expire.
- A capped number of seats (he mentions caps and “spots left at founder’s pricing”).
- Seasonal discounts (a holiday sale).
- Waitlists, then “sold out in a few days” social proof.

He describes this as a rhythm: a launch roughly every quarter, each with new content and often a higher price DEMO.

Why it works. People postpone. A real deadline converts “someday” into “now”. Raising the price rewards early believers and gives you an honest reason to follow up.

Do it. Only use scarcity that is true. If you say the price rises on Friday, raise it on Friday. If you say fifteen seats, stop at fifteen. Koe himself, once, told readers that no further letter would arrive before a deadline, which is the honest style. The aggressive style (fake countdowns, invented discounts) trades long-term trust for a short-term lift. For a writer whose product is trust, it is a bad exchange.

Lesson 11: Making the offer legible inside an essay-led newsletter

What Koe does. He lets the free letters carry the offer in small, predictable slots DEMO: a labelled block at the top or middle (a reminder, a plain self-promotion note readers may skip), a postscript with the deadline, a footer menu of two or three products ordered by price with one sentence of purpose each, and a recurring weekly roundup at the end listing new videos, community items, and any open enrollment. He sometimes places the pitch before the essay and sometimes after a philosophical turn, framed as a continuation. Even off-topic letters end with a short “when you are ready” block. He also gives the newsletter itself a job: it is the stealth sales page, linked under posts, with a product mentioned at least once inside it OPINION.

Why it works. Readers learn where the offer lives, so the essay itself stays uninterrupted. Labelling is respectful, and a menu ordered by price lets each reader pick their own level of commitment.

Do it.

1. Create one reusable footer block: two lines for the main offer, one line for the lead magnet, one line for the free archive.
2. Add a clearly labelled top note only in launch weeks.
3. Keep at least three of every four letters free of any ask beyond the footer.

OFFER WORKSHEET (PRINTABLE)

Field	Your answer
Who I help (point A person)	
Their top three pains (from forms and replies)	
Point B (specific, measurable)	
Timeframe	
Mechanism name	
Steps of the mechanism (3 to 7)	
Format (service / cohort / tutorial / program / system)	
Angle (desire it serves)	
Price and why	
Bonuses (2 to 3, real)	
Guarantee (what exactly)	
Capacity (seats)	
Deadline I can truthfully state	
Proof I have today	
Proof I need to earn	

EXERCISES (PART 5)

EXERCISE 5.1: THREE CANDIDATE FIRST OFFERS (30 MINUTES)

Deliverable: pick one offer from the table, with one reason.

Offer	Fit for an essay-led writer	Pros	Cons
A. Essay-collection ebook ($12 to $29)	Natural: repackages existing work	Fast (under a week), cheap test of demand, sits well with a general readership	Low revenue per sale; you get no customer conversation; "a collection" is a weak outcome promise unless curated around one theme
B. Writing/thinking cohort ($99 to $199, 2 to 4 weeks)	Strong: essays show your thinking, which is the skill taught	Higher revenue, scarcity is natural, builds curriculum and testimonials	Needs you to define who is behind you; requires live time; outcome must be deliverable
C. Paid tier on Substack ($5 to $10/month)	Natural: uses the existing platform	Recurring, no new tool	Platform fee (Koe notes roughly 10 percent plus processing on Substack); needs steady extra output; not a ladder rung by itself
D. Micro service: four one-to-one essay sessions ($300 to $750)	Good if you enjoy coaching	Highest revenue per buyer, direct learning	Time-bound, a service not a product; may not be wanted by you

EXERCISE 5.2: FILL THE OFFER WORKSHEET (45 MINUTES)

Deliverable: one completed page for your chosen offer.

EXERCISE 5.3: BUILD THE QUALIFICATION FORM (30 MINUTES)

Deliverable: a six-question form live at a link. Send it to three trusted readers for feedback.

EXERCISE 5.4: NAME THE MECHANISM (20 MINUTES)

Deliverable: five candidate names, one chosen, a one-sentence description.

EXERCISE 5.5: WRITE THE THREE DM TEMPLATES (15 MINUTES)

Deliverable: opener, value tip, soft offer, in your voice.

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 5)

1. **Does selling to beginners fit your readership?** Koe argues most social audiences are beginners and the first product should target them [OPINION]. Jono's readers came for essays on ideas. Are they beginners at something you could teach, or are they thoughtful readers who want more of the thinking? What evidence do you have either way, and how could you gather it this month?
2. **Is a service offer something you would want to do?** The ladder starts with one-to-one work because it teaches fast. If you dislike coaching, what would you lose by skipping it, and what could replace the learning it gives?
3. **What can you honestly promise?** Write the outcome of your offer, then write the percentage of buyers you believe would reach it. If you would not bet your own money on that percentage, how should the promise change?

RECAP (PART 5)

The ladder runs: free writing, lead magnet, micro service or product, cohort, course, community. Each rung feeds the next.

Decide marketing first: angle, believable goal, transformation, bonuses, price, risk reversal.

The mechanism is a named, repeatable process. Name it and use the name in free essays.

The qualification form and a short, bounded DM conversation turn interest into customers without a sales page.

Scarcity works when it is true.

Koe’s figures are his own. Plan from your own audience, not his.

PART 06

06

Courses and Digital Products

Design, test and pre-sell your first course or digital product.

- → Market research for a first product
- → Choose a delivery mode
- → Curriculum design
- → Progress tracking
- → Writing versus video
- → Platforms
- → Pre-selling
- → Using testimonials
- → How Koe's own products evolved

Intro

Part 5 chose the offer. Part 6 builds it. Koe's approach is practical and compressed: research what already sells, choose a delivery mode, write a curriculum that bridges point A to B, add a way to track progress, and sell before it is finished. He also changed his view of what a product is over the years, from static course to system to software, and that evolution is worth understanding before you choose.

Lesson 1: Market research for a first product

What Koe does. In the mega guide he gives an order of reliability DEMO/OPINION:

1. **Your own best-performing posts and newsletters.** What your audience already rewarded.
2. **Top-performing ideas from creators in your space.** Sort their videos or posts by popularity, log titles, hooks, and notes.
3. **Audience replies and recurring questions.** He says question posts start working around 2,500 followers.
4. **Five to ten free calls with beginners,** found by commenting thoughtfully then sending a short compliment message.
5. **Buying and studying mentors' courses, emails, funnels, and sales pages,** as a builder rather than a consumer.

His principle is to sell what already sells, with a small improvement and your own named mechanism. Competition is a good sign, because people buy several courses on one topic OPINION. He describes buying five to ten courses before making his own and, for a planner idea, buying four or five bestsellers, testing them on himself, and reverse-engineering their pages DEMO. He also suggests using AI to dissect a purchased competitor's structure and reusing it as a skeleton, which means learning from structure, not copying content.

He often points to viral content as demand data: his writing course came from a thread that performed, and a one-person business course came from a viral video, with the landing page built fast and selling started before the product was finished DEMO.

Why it works. You are using proof instead of guesses. Each source answers a different question: what do my readers value, what does the market value, and what words do buyers use.

Do it.

1. List your ten best-performing essays and notes. Find the shared idea.
2. Open three adjacent creators and write down their five most popular titles.
3. Scan your last 100 reader comments and emails for repeated questions.
4. Run three free conversations (see the script below).
5. Buy one competing product. Map its sections.

> *Call invitation, own wording: "I'm designing something to help people [outcome]. Would you give me 20 minutes to hear what you've tried? No pitch."*

Ethical note. Buying and mapping a product is fine. Reproducing its content or its distinctive framework is not. Borrow structure; supply your own substance.

Lesson 2: Choose a delivery mode

What Koe does. He names three modes OPINION:

Mode	What it is	Best for
Tutorial	Teaches a skill	A defined skill with a clear end state
Program	A step-by-step regimen with a schedule	Habit or behavior change

Mode	What it is	Best for
System	Your own method, named	When you have a mechanism

He also uses a different taxonomy: do it yourself (course), done with you (coaching, cohort), done for you (service). He argues courses fail because buyers cannot adapt a static lesson to their situation, which is why he moved toward products that carry prompts or tools that act on the buyer's context OPINION, TESTED IN HIS OWN CHALLENGE, PER HIS CLAIM.

On the format of the first product: cohort first, then spin out a course OPINION, and around the $150 range for his beginner-facing products DEMO.

Why it works. The mode tells you the structure. A tutorial is a sequence of techniques. A program is a calendar. A system is a method plus examples.

Do it. For an essay writer, the natural mode is **system** (your way of finding, shaping, and finishing an essay), delivered as a **program** (a two to four week schedule). A pure tutorial on "how to write" competes with a thousand others.

Lesson 3: Curriculum design

What Koe does. The outline logic is simple DEMO/OPINION:

1. Define where they are, where they want to be, and what bridges the gap (skills, beliefs, habits).
2. Make each bridge a module.
3. Treat each module as one technique, because skills are groups of techniques. He says each module of his writing course is a technique DEMO.
4. Write the modules like newsletters: problem, amplify, key points (PAK), or attention, interest, desire, action (AIDA).
5. Document your process as if instructing a new hire. That documentation is the curriculum outline, he says DEMO.
6. Keep persuading inside the course so students act and produce results you can later quote as testimonials.

His four-step build for an AI-assisted product: write the process as employee instructions; convert each step to a two-phase prompt (gather context, then produce); run it on yourself until the result is 80 to 90 percent as good as yours; then write documentation teaching both the task and the prompts DEMO. Whether that suits an essay writer is a real question (see Challenge below).

Why it works. The bridge framing keeps the course small and tied to a result. One technique per module makes the course checkable.

Do it. Draw a line with A on the left and B on the right. Write every step you take between them. Group into three to seven modules. Under each module write: the technique, one example, one action, one deliverable.

Lesson 4: Progress tracking

What Koe does. He adds projects, worksheets, and templates so the buyer produces something along the way OPINION. In his challenge format, there is a daily lesson plus a 30 to 60 minute action. His broader claim: information is labor, and people who do not pay do not pay attention; courses fail because people do not implement OPINION. Self-paced products are weaker on completion, which is why he favors cohorts and challenges.

Why it works. A finished artifact is the best proof for the buyer and the best testimonial for you.

Do it.

- One deliverable per module (for example: a hook, an outline, a draft, a revision).
- A simple checklist or tracker the student updates.
- A weekly check-in, even a short written one.
- Define "done" for the course: the finished essay.

Lesson 5: Writing versus video

What Koe does. For his beginner-priced course, he recommends writing for theory and video for implementation OPINION. For newsletters-as-product, he writes modules like letters. He chose long form (writing, podcast, video) over short form on purpose for the product side DEMO, and says 95 percent of his sales come from long-form content DEMO, SELF-REPORTED, EARLY ERA.

Why it works. Writing is searchable, quick to produce, and cheap to update. Video is stronger for showing process on screen.

Do it. Write every module. Add short screen recordings only where seeing the work helps (an essay edited live). That keeps production under a few weeks and plays to Jono's strength.

Lesson 6: Platforms

What Koe does. His stack across years DEMO: Stan for standalone products and quick payment pages, Circle for community or cohort, Beehiiv for the newsletter, forms for qualification, and Carrd for a custom page. He notes Substack is workable but takes about 10 percent plus processing for paid subscriptions OPINION. He says to skip company formation and design until you have earned something OPINION, and not to let tooling delay selling.

Do it. Use what you already have first. A Substack post can be the sales page; a Substack paid tier or a payment link can take money; a free shared document can be the first delivery. Move when the volume justifies the work.

Lesson 7: Pre-selling

What Koe does. He repeatedly recommends selling before building DEMO. Set a launch date three to four weeks away, publish the offer with a page, accept orders, and use the deadline to force the build. He says if one person pays you must build the minimum product or refund, and that this forces action; one cohort took him only a few hours to build, with live delivery DEMO. He also describes announcing a waitlist with social proof such as "150 waiting" DEMO.

Why it works. A paying customer is the strongest validation. The date removes perfectionism.

Do it.

1. Write the page (Part 7), set the date, and state the delivery clearly.
2. Cap seats at a number you can serve well.
3. Promise only what you can build in the time left. State what is in the product on day one and what will arrive later.
4. Offer refunds if you miss the date.

Ethical note. Pre-selling is honest only if buyers know it is a pre-sale. Say so on the page.

Lesson 8: Using testimonials

What Koe does. For a first product he suggests trading free walkthroughs for feedback, since early proof is rare DEMO/OPINION. He says testimonials from other creators become appreciating assets as they grow OPINION. He also advises not to wait for testimonials: start pages and posts with your own experience as proof OPINION. In launches he uses screenshot proof and enrollment counts DEMO.

Do it.

- Ask for a specific result, not praise: "What changed for you, in numbers or in a sentence?"
- Get permission in writing to quote.

- Never edit a testimonial into something the person did not say.
- Use ordinary numbers honestly. “57 enrolled” must be true on the day.

Lesson 9: How Koe’s own products evolved

What Koe does. Reading across the letters (many dated only approximately), the pattern looks like this DEMO, SELF-REPORTED:

Era (approximate)	Product shape	Lesson he draws
Early 2020s	Freelance and web-design courses, a planner, a social growth product	Sell the solution to your own problem; cheap products validate
Year 2 on social	Offer-creation course (he says it flopped from too little promotion), consulting, a community built from material already published	Underpromotion, not the idea, killed it
Mid period	Writing course from his own newsletter templates, a masterclass, then cohorts (a 14-day sprint at $150, a four-call cohort)	Cohorts concentrate revenue and create scarcity
Later	Book, premium tier, challenges (30 to 60 days)	Use challenges as the entry offer
2024 to 2026	Software, AI-assisted tools, bootcamp cohorts, co-taught workshops, paid-subscriber guides	Put education and execution in one product

Common thread: a new launch about every quarter for years DEMO, and pivot to a new product rather than selling one forever OPINION. He also says once a product sells, effort should shift to audience growth, and that he had one flop he blames on promotion DEMO.

Why it matters for Jono. Koe’s later products depend on software and a giant audience. The early shape (a cheap, writing-centered product built from your own templates and process) is the transferable part.

EXERCISES (PART 6)

EXERCISE 6.1: RESEARCH SPRINT (90 MINUTES OVER ONE WEEK)

Deliverables: a table of your ten best essays with the shared idea; five competitor titles; a tally of repeated reader questions.

EXERCISE 6.2: THREE RESEARCH CALLS (3 X 20 MINUTES)

Deliverable: a one-page summary of the phrases buyers used for their struggle.

EXERCISE 6.3: CURRICULUM ON ONE PAGE (45 MINUTES)

Deliverable: A-to-B line, three to seven modules, one deliverable per module.

EXERCISE 6.4: COMPETITOR TEARDOWN (60 MINUTES)

Deliverable: map of one purchased product’s sections, price, promise, guarantee, and what it lacks.

EXERCISE 6.5: CHOOSE A FIRST-PRODUCT SHAPE (20 MINUTES)

Use the Part 5 table. Deliverable: one paragraph defending the choice.

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 6)

1. **Is "sell what already sells" compatible with an original voice?** Koe's method starts from market demand and adds a mechanism. Jono's readers may value originality over utility. What would a product look like that sells because it is distinctive, and is that a risk worth taking?
2. **Do you want a course at all?** Koe himself says courses cannot fit every student and have low completion. Would a smaller thing, like a cohort or an essay collection, serve readers better?
3. **What are you willing to deliver?** If you pre-sell with a date, can you protect the time to build, and what happens to buyers if you cannot?

RECAP (PART 6)

Research from proof: your own best posts, competitors' best titles, reader questions, a few calls.

Choose tutorial, program, or system. A named system delivered as a short program suits an essay writer.

Build the curriculum as modules that each teach one technique and produce one deliverable.

Pre-sell with a real date and cap.

Collect specific, permissioned testimonials.

Koe's products evolved toward cohort and software. The early cheap, writing-based shape is the one to copy.

PART 07

07

Landing Pages and Launches

Write the page, set the date, run a three-week launch.

- → PASTOR
- → Page section order
- → Headline formula
- → The AI-assisted drafting workflow (method, not prompt text)
- → A skeleton page for a writing cohort (own example)
- → If it does not sell
- → The 3-week launch calendar
- → Scarcity design
- → Post-launch

Intro

A product without a page and a plan is a file. Koe's approach to selling is plain: write a page with a known structure, draft it with an AI assistant as a starting point, then run a three-week sequence of mentions that gets heavier as the deadline approaches. He is clear that the usual reason a product does not sell is promotion and content, not page design OPINION.

Lesson 1: PASTOR

What Koe does. He uses PASTOR as the spine of long-form sales copy: Problem, Amplify, Story, Testimony, Offer, Response OPINION/DEMO. Elsewhere he mentions PAS (problem, amplify, solution) and AIDA as shorter variants.

Why it works. It follows how a reader decides: do I have this problem, does it matter, can I trust you, does it work for others, what exactly is offered, what do I do now.

Do it. Draft each as one paragraph first.

- **Problem:** the reader's frustration in their words (from your form).
- **Amplify:** what it costs them to stay stuck.
- **Story:** your own path from stuck to unstuck, briefly.
- **Testimony:** the proof you have.
- **Offer:** what they get, by module, with the mechanism name.
- **Response:** a clear action and the deadline.

Lesson 2: Page section order

What Koe does. In his landing page guide for paid subscribers, he gives this order DEMO/OPINION:

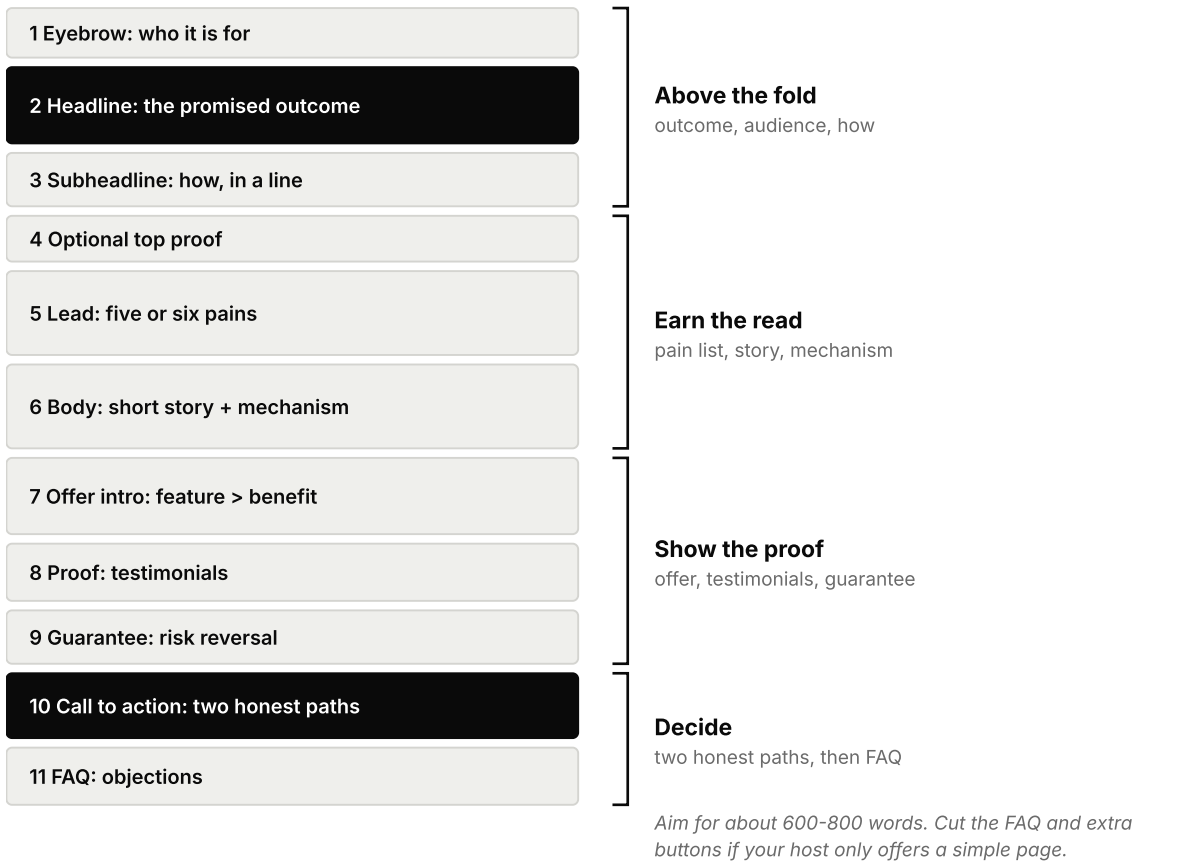


Figure 6. Section order for a landing page, grouped by what each stretch of the page must do.

#	Section	Purpose
1	Eyebrow	Names who it is for
2	Headline	The promised outcome
3	Subheadline	How, in a line
4	Optional top proof	A number or quote
5	Lead (pain list)	Five or six pains that qualify the reader
6	Body	Short story plus the mechanism
7	Offer intro	Features, each with its benefit
8	Proof	Testimonials, results
9	Guarantee	Risk reversal
10	Call to action	Two honest paths: buy, or keep working it out alone
11	FAQ	Objections

Length target: roughly 600 to 800 words, shorter for creators because existing audience trust does some of the persuading OPINION. He says text-only pages often convert well OPINION/DEMO and that top sections should be fast. In an earlier guide, he lists a similar order with before/after and FAQ only for custom pages.

Why it works. The order moves from relevance to credibility to action. The two-path ending respects the reader's choice.

Do it. Write the page in a plain document. Host it on any simple tool or as a Substack post with a payment link. Do not spend a week on design.

Lesson 3: Headline formula

What Koe does. The formula: [desired outcome] without [main pain or inconvenience] DEMO/OPINION. Generate ten to twenty variants and pick one. He also suggests the lead include a “bullet spray” of five to six qualifying pains.

Why it works. It names the reward and removes the obstacle in one line, and forcing many variants beats settling for the first.

Do it. Write twenty in ten minutes. Examples in your own flavor: “A finished essay every week without waiting for inspiration”; “Clear writing without the blank-page dread.” Choose the one a skeptical reader would still believe.

Honesty check. The headline is a promise. If you cannot deliver “every week”, write “in four weeks”.

Lesson 4: The AI-assisted drafting workflow (method, not prompt text)

What Koe does. He describes a method for building a copywriting assistant DEMO:

1. Ask a reasoning model to produce a detailed copywriting guide drawn from a well-known book or two.
2. Ask the model what information it would need from you to write the page.
3. Combine the two into a single instruction in two phases: first interview you to gather context, then write.
4. Supply the facts about your product, audience, mechanism, proof, and price.
5. Get a first draft only. Then edit as the customer: shorten sentences, write to one person, begin sections with a problem, idea, stat, or quote, draft without judging then edit.

His advice that output quality depends on input quality is the key. In an offer-building workflow, he runs the AI through a brand interview, an avatar, an offer blueprint, a text-only page, and then posts and emails, and insists on treating the output as drafts rather than final copy DEMO/OPINION. A related point: he does not post AI output as is, and a commenter’s test of AI articles still sounded generic, which supports using it for scaffolding DEMO.

Why it works. The interview step forces you to articulate the offer. The draft step overcomes blank-page delay. The editing step restores your voice.

Do it.

1. Collect your inputs first: form answers, testimonials, the module list, price, guarantee.
2. Use your preferred AI assistant to get a first draft.
3. Read it aloud. Cut every sentence you would not say.
4. Check every claim against reality.
5. Rewrite the headline, the first paragraph, and the call to action by hand.

Caution. Do not let the tool invent testimonials, numbers, or results. Every fact on the page must be one you can show.

Lesson 4b: A skeleton page for a writing cohort (own example)

This is an illustrative outline, not a template to copy word for word. Every bracket must be replaced with a fact you can prove.

- **Eyebrow:** For readers who want to publish their own essays.
- **Headline:** [Finished essay] in [four weeks] without [waiting for inspiration].
- **Subheadline:** A small cohort built around [your named method]; [number] seats.
- **Lead:** Five or six lines that begin “You have…” describing real situations from your form responses.
- **Body:** Two short paragraphs of your own story, then the method in three to five named steps.

- **What you get:** Week-by-week list; beside each item, the benefit in one clause.
- **Proof:** Two specific testimonials, or an honest sentence that this is the first cohort and why the price reflects it.
- **Guarantee:** [Exactly what you will do if the student completes the work and is unsatisfied.]
- **Call to action:** Join by [date], or keep writing on your own, which is a fine choice.
- **FAQ:** Time per week, experience level, what happens if you miss a session, refund terms.

A first cohort with no proof should say so. A plain “this is the first run” is more persuasive to a thoughtful readership than borrowed credibility.

Lesson 5: If it does not sell

What Koe does. He argues that content or promotion is the usual cause, and that tests should be separated: if posts get no views, write better; if views do not become buyers, sell better; check perception as the variable OPINION. He also notes the order of diagnosis: no clicks means pain points or network; no sales means offer or copy.

Do it. Keep a launch log with four numbers: views of the promotion, clicks to the page, page visits to purchases, and replies. Change one thing at a time.

Lesson 6: The 3-week launch calendar

What Koe does. In his launch guide for paid subscribers, he assumes a daily short post and a weekly long piece. The plan DEMO, “MY ROUTINE FOR YEARS”:

- Choose a date at least three weeks out and narrow content toward the product topic.
- **Week 1 (soft):** mention the product in the newsletter near the top and in the postscript. Under the day’s best short post, after one to two hours, link the newsletter, not the product.
- **Week 2 (harder):** list the problems the product solves. Under the best post each day, add a short plug with the deadline, in the form “if you struggle with A, B, or C, [product] closes on [date].” Use automated direct-message tools where replies are not seen.
- **Week 3:** repeat. For the final three days, post a standalone promotion each day. On the last day, send two emails and a last-call post.
- Typical shape: slow in week one, up in week two, surge in week three and the final two days.

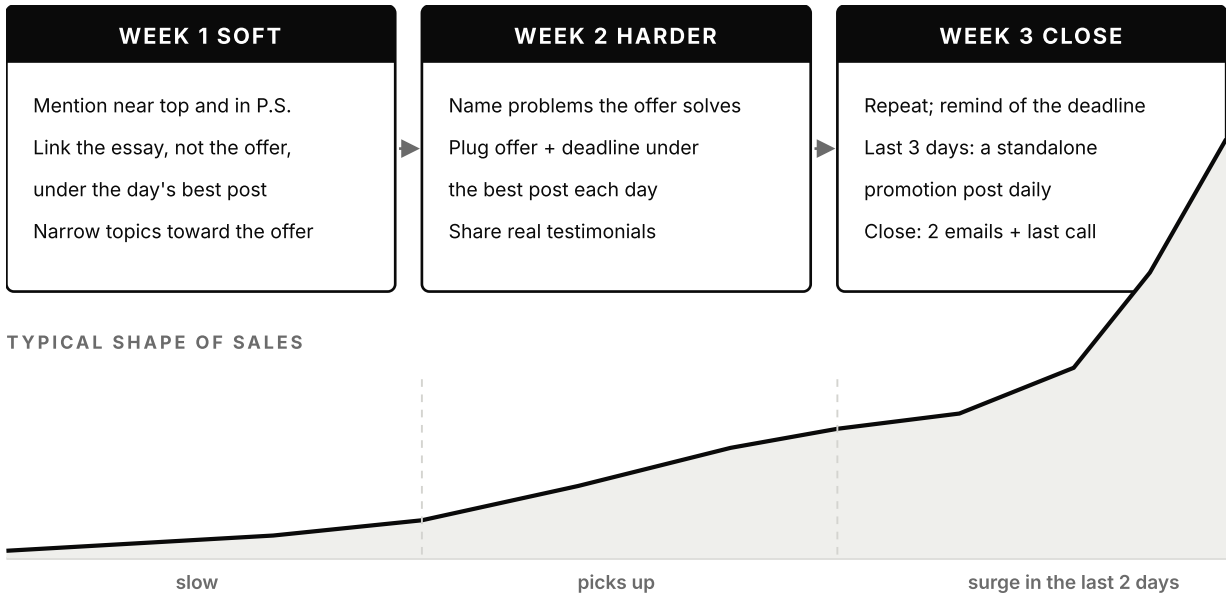


Figure 7. The three-week launch pattern described in the sources, with the typical shape of sales.

He also says network reposts matter and that a 1,000-follower account with a strong network can out-earn a larger account OPINION.

Printable launch calendar (adapt to your channels; replace "social" with Notes/X/LinkedIn as relevant):

Day	Newsletter	Social post	Other	Done
W1 Mon	Weekly essay on the product topic; one mention at top	Post 1 with newsletter link	Publish page quietly to a few trusted readers	☐
W1 Tue		Post, newsletter link	Log questions	☐
W1 Wed		Post, newsletter link		☐
W1 Thu		Post, newsletter link	Open the form for early interest	☐
W1 Fri	P.S. mention	Post, newsletter link		☐
W1 Sat/Sun		Rest or reply to comments	Fix the page from feedback	☐
W2 Mon	Essay naming the problems the product solves; mention near top	Post + plug with deadline		☐
W2 Tue		Post + plug	Send early-interest list a note	☐
W2 Wed	Mid-week short email: one story from a research call	Post + plug		☐
W2 Thu		Post + plug	Share a real testimonial	☐
W2 Fri	P.S. with deadline	Post + plug		☐
W2 Sat/Sun		Reply to questions	Count seats sold	☐
W3 Mon	Essay on the transformation; offer block near top	Post + plug	Remind: price rise date	☐
W3 Tue		Post + plug	Answer objections in a post	☐
W3 Wed	Short email: FAQ	Post + plug		☐
W3 Thu (3 days left)		Standalone promotion post		☐
W3 Fri (2 days left)	Email: what is inside	Standalone promotion post		☐
W3 Sat (1 day left)		Standalone promotion post		☐
Close day	**Email 1:** full final-day message. **Email 2:** short reminder 4 to 6 hours before close	Last-call post, details in replies	Close on the stated time	☐
Day after	Thank-you and what to expect	Honest recap	Send onboarding	☐

The two-email final day. Email 1 is the complete message: who it is for, what it is, the proof, the deadline, the link. Email 2 is short, four to six hours before close, and says only that it closes soon and gives the link. Koe also suggests a last-call post with the details in a reply, deleted afterward DEMO. Deleting is optional and cosmetic. If you do, do not pretend it never existed.

Why it works. The ramp avoids exhausting readers early, concentrates attention where purchase intent is greatest, and uses topic-narrowed content to warm the audience before the ask.

Do it. Block the calendar, write the emails in advance, and decide in advance what you will not do (see ethical limits below).

Lesson 7: Scarcity design

What Koe does. He builds scarcity into the offer, not the copy: a closing date, a rising price, expiring bonuses, a cap, a seasonal sale DEMO. He advises using scarcity sparingly OPINION. He labels promotions openly in free letters, with a "skip this if you dislike self-promotion" note, and a self-sponsorship block at the top DEMO.

Ethical rules to adopt:

- Every deadline is real. Close on time. Do not reopen the same offer at the same price immediately after saying it is over.
- The seat cap is a number you chose for delivery reasons.
- Bonuses are real and are delivered.
- Label promotion plainly. Readers who stay are choosing to.
- Do not use fear of missing out about outcomes you cannot guarantee.
- Paid reposts (which he describes as a controversial tactic, at budgets in the hundreds to thousands per set of reposts) should be disclosed if the platform or audience would expect it. For a trust-led writer, the cost of being found out exceeds the benefit.

Lesson 8: Post-launch

What Koe does. After a launch, he builds the product with feedback, improves it for the next round, and raises the price DEMO. He also treats launches as cycles: maintenance mode between them, and focus on the launch for one to two months when it happens DEMO. He describes a record launch month as a "new baseline" he could not sustain, and returns to a normal routine afterward DEMO. He recommends reviewing what worked monthly and re-running, bundling, or turning a cohort into a standalone course using testimonials DEMO/OPINION. He also notes that people still do not know about a three-year-old book, so keep promoting OPINION.

Do it.

1. Within 48 hours: send onboarding and a short thank-you.
2. During delivery: log every question; it is next version's content.
3. At the end: request specific testimonials and permission.
4. Within two weeks of close: write a debrief with numbers: views, clicks, buyers, refunds, hours.
5. Decide: rerun, raise price, or convert to a course.
6. Tell your readers honestly what happened, including what did not work. It also makes good essay material.

EXERCISES (PART 7)

EXERCISE 7.1: TWENTY HEADLINES (10 MINUTES)

Deliverable: twenty variants, three shortlisted, one chosen.

EXERCISE 7.2: PASTOR IN SIX PARAGRAPHS (45 MINUTES)

Deliverable: one paragraph per letter, using real inputs.

EXERCISE 7.3: DRAFT THE PAGE (90 MINUTES)

Deliverable: an 11-section page of 600 to 800 words. Use an AI draft only after you have gathered your inputs, then edit by hand.

EXERCISE 7.4: FILL THE LAUNCH CALENDAR (60 MINUTES)

Deliverable: dates, the three newsletter mentions, the final-day emails written, and a list of what you will not do.

EXERCISE 7.5: PRE-REGISTER YOUR SUCCESS CRITERIA (15 MINUTES)

Deliverable: three numbers (minimum buyers to run the cohort, target, refund threshold), written before launch.

CHALLENGE YOUR ASSUMPTIONS (PART 7)

1. **Is a three-week promotional ramp consistent with your voice?** Koe's method is repetitive and direct. Your readers may subscribe for essays, not offers. What proportion of your letters could be promotional before the trust you built starts to erode, and how would you know?
2. **Does the scarcity you are using exist, or are you manufacturing it?** Pick each deadline and ask whether you would honor it if a friend missed it by an hour.
3. **What would success look like at your scale?** Koe's launch stories come from audiences far larger than yours. If a launch brings in five buyers, was it a failure, or did it prove the offer?

RECAP (PART 7)

Write the page with PASTOR and the 11-section order; headline = outcome without pain.

Use AI to get from blank to draft, never to invent facts or replace your voice.

Run the three-week ramp: soft, harder, final push, with two emails on the last day.

Build scarcity that is real, and label promotion.

After the launch, debrief, deliver, collect testimonials, and decide the next version.

All figures are Koe's. Measure your own.

PART 08

08

The 90-Day Plan

Thirteen weeks, one dashboard, three decision gates.

- → How the plan is built
- → The dashboard
- → The daily two-hour block
- → The thirteen weeks
- → Week 1: Direction and baseline (Part 1)
- → Week 2: The idea system (Part 2)
- → Week 3: First full cycle (Parts 2, 3, 4)
- → Week 4: Rhythm and first review (Parts 3, 4)
- → Week 5: Listening for the offer (Parts 4, 5)
- → Week 6: Lead magnet and offer shape (Part 5)
- → Week 7: Soft-test the micro offer (Parts 5, 6)
- → Week 8: Deliver, learn, decision gate 2 (Parts 5, 6)
- → Week 9: Build the product, date the launch (Parts 6, 7)
- → Week 10: Launch week 1, soft (Part 7)
- → Week 11: Launch week 2, harder (Part 7)
- → Week 12: Launch week 3, close; decision gate 3 (Part 7)

This part turns Parts 1 to 7 into a schedule. It assumes about two hours a day, six days a week, for 13 weeks. If you have less time, keep the order and stretch the weeks. Do not skip the order: the earlier weeks create the audience signal and the evidence the later weeks depend on.

How the plan is built

Three phases.

Phase	Weeks	Purpose	Parts used
Engine	1-4	Clarify direction, build the idea system, establish a weekly publishing rhythm	1, 2, 3, 4
Offer	5-8	Learn what readers want to pay for; ship a small first offer	4, 5, 6
Launch	9-13	Build a first product, run a dated launch, review	6, 7

One rule for the whole plan. Every week ends with exactly one change you will make next week, chosen from your evidence log. Not three. One. Koe's recurring advice is to treat your work as an experiment with feedback. OPINION An experiment with ten variables teaches nothing.

A note on pace. Koe describes 6 to 12 months of consistent work before growth turns visible, and says a lot of early output goes nowhere. OPINION / DEMO Ninety days is long enough to build the machine, collect honest signal and ship one small offer. It is not long enough to judge the whole model. The week-12 review is designed to protect you from both quitting too early and persisting blindly.

The dashboard

Track eight numbers every Sunday in a single table or sheet. It should take ten minutes. If it takes longer, you are tracking too much.

#	Metric	Definition	Where it comes from
1	**New subscribers**	Net new email subscribers in the week (gross, and unsubscribes noted separately)	Your newsletter stats page
2	**Open or read rate**	For the week's essay: share of recipients who opened it (or whichever read measure your platform gives). Note that open rates are noisy	Newsletter stats
3	**Notes / posts published**	Count of short-form posts published, and number of essays published	Your own tally
4	**Replies**	Reader replies to emails plus meaningful comments or replies (not likes) that engage with the idea	Inbox and platform
5	**Lead magnet signups**	Subscribers who joined via the lead magnet (from week 5 onward)	Tool or tagged link
6	**Conversations started**	Real two-way exchanges: DMs that went beyond one message, calls, or detailed email threads. Count people, not messages	Your log
7	**Offer interest**	People who raised a hand for the offer: replied "yes", filled a form, joined a waitlist, asked the price. Count people	Form, inbox
8	**Revenue**	Money received for anything you sell, in the week	Payment tool

Why these eight. The first three tell you whether the engine is running. Metrics 4 and 6 tell you whether anyone cares. Metrics 5 and 7 tell you whether the ladder is working. Metric 8 tells you whether it matters. Koe's own list of "levers" counts actions you control (posts written, words written) in addition to results, and says to track the former when the latter are noisy. OPINION Metric 3 is the action metric.

How to use them.

- Record the number and the **direction against the prior 3-week average**. A single week is noise. A trend across three weeks is a signal.
- Add one line of context for any odd week (travel, illness, a viral post).

- Set targets **after week 3**, using your own baseline. Do not borrow Koe's benchmarks. His figures came from audiences far larger than yours. A sensible first target is "better than my 3-week median" for each metric. Ask whether you can double a ratio you actually control, such as replies per essay, rather than whether you can match someone else's reach.

Two derived ratios worth computing at the end of each phase.

1. *Subscribers per essay published* (new subscribers divided by essays published in the period).
2. *Offer interest per 100 active readers* (offer interest divided by your list size, times 100). This is the most useful number in the plan, and you will not have it until around week 6.

The daily two-hour block

Koe describes a two-hour daily routine: about an hour on the newsletter, thirty minutes on short posts, thirty minutes on engagement and linking. DEMO He also describes doing deep work first thing, before email or the phone, and never starting with maintenance work. DEMO The plan adopts that structure and varies it by phase.

Standard block (Engine phase).

Minutes	Activity	Notes
0-60	Deep writing	Essay, outline, or the week's product work. Phone away. Quantify the target, such as "write 800 words", not "work on the essay"
60-90	Short-form	Write that day's 1-3 short posts. Draw on the idea museum
90-120	Engagement and linking	Reply to others, send a few thoughtful DMs, link the newsletter under the day's best post

Offer-phase block (weeks 5-8). Shorten deep writing to 45 minutes. Add 30 minutes of **conversations**: DMs, replies to subscribers, call scheduling, form review.

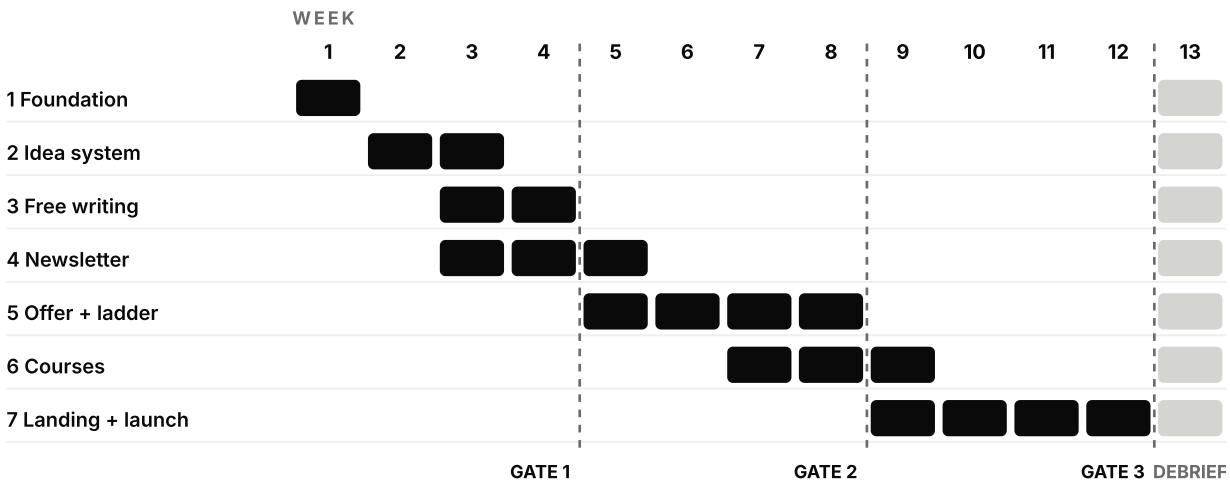
Launch-phase block (weeks 9-13). Deep writing becomes product and launch work (60 minutes). Short-form narrows to the product topic. Engagement and DMs shift to warm leads.

Sixth day. Use it for the lighter work: reading, a walk for idea hunting, and replying to readers. Koe repeatedly describes walks as his main idea engine, and writes of using the afternoon for input and the morning for output. DEMO Seventh day off.

When life interrupts. Protect the first 60 minutes. If you can only do one thing, do the writing. If you can do two, add engagement. Short-form is the first thing to drop.

The thirteen weeks

Each week has: **focus**, **do** (mapped to Parts 1-7), **deliverable** (the thing that exists at the end of the week), **metrics** (what to watch), and **check** (the question for Sunday's review).



Dark bars: parts you work on that week. Dashed lines: decision gates after weeks 4, 8 and 12.

Figure 8. The 13-week plan: which part you work on each week, and when to make decisions.

Week 1: Direction and baseline (Part 1)

- **Focus:** know what you are building and for whom, and set up the instruments.
- **Do:** Answer the five questions from the front matter. Write an anti-vision (the life or kind of work you reject) and a minimum viable vision, 30 minutes each. Koe's method starts from what you want to avoid and inverts it. OPINION Write a point A to point B sentence for your reader. Draft a one-line bio in the form "I write about X so you can Y". Set up the dashboard and evidence log. Record your **baseline** numbers: list size, last four essays' open rates, your average views.
- **Deliverable:** One page titled "Why, for whom, how I will know" plus a populated week-0 dashboard row.
- **Metrics:** Baseline only. No targets.
- **Check:** Could a stranger read my page and say who my reader is?

Week 2: The idea system (Part 2)

- **Focus:** build the intake and capture habit that feeds everything else.
- **Do:** Start an **idea museum**: one place where every idea is saved instantly. Make two collections: ideas that performed (yours or others') and ideas that excite you. Koe says the best posts sit where those overlap. OPINION List 3-5 idea-dense sources (older books, curated blogs, a few thinkers) and a short list of 5 writers you will check instead of scrolling a feed. DEMO Draw a **content map** on paper: your mission, 2-3 broad territories, 3-5 subtopics each, 3-5 ideas per subtopic. Run the "one idea, five angles" exercise on three saved ideas.
- **Deliverable:** A populated idea museum (30+ items), a source list, a one-page content map.
- **Metrics:** Notes published (start at 1 a day); everything else baseline.
- **Check:** Do I have more ideas waiting than I can write this month?

Week 3: First full cycle (Parts 2, 3, 4)

- **Focus:** complete the loop of idea, short posts, essay, link, once.
- **Do:** Outline the week's essay on Monday, in the idea museum, with a point, three arguments, support and a story. Koe describes this pyramid-style outline and says to start the week with it. DEMO Draft, edit, publish by Thursday. Cut the essay into 5-7 standalone short posts (rewrite each so it stands alone with its own hook; do not paste excerpts). DEMO Link the essay under your best post each day. Spend the third block on **non-needy networking**: pick people near your own size, send sincere, specific notes, be useful. OPINION

- **Deliverable:** One published essay, 5+ short posts, 5 outreach notes sent.
- **Metrics:** Essays (1), notes (7+), conversations started, replies.
- **Check:** Which short post got the strongest response, and why do I think so?

Week 4: Rhythm and first review (Parts 3, 4)

- **Focus:** lock the weekly rhythm; run decision gate 1.
- **Do:** Publish essay 2. Write a **welcome email** and ensure new subscribers get one. Study 3 writers' best posts using the structure dissector (Appendix C) and rewrite one idea in a borrowed structure. Run the **week-4 review** (see "Decision rules" below).
- **Deliverable:** Two essays published in weeks 3-4, a welcome email, a week-4 decision memo (half a page).
- **Metrics:** Compare weeks 3-4 to the baseline.
- **Check:** Is the rhythm sustainable at this load for another nine weeks?

Week 5: Listening for the offer (Parts 4, 5)

- **Focus:** find what readers would pay for.
- **Do:** Mine your own data: your best-performing essays and posts, and the questions in replies. Koe ranks these first as product research. DEMO Run 5 short conversations with subscribers (chat or call). Ask where they are now, what they have tried, what they wish existed. Ask about problems, not about your product. Draft an **audience question form** (5 questions, with a multiple-choice "biggest struggle" item and a readiness scale). DEMO Pick a lead magnet topic from the strongest signal.
- **Deliverable:** A list of 10 recurring reader problems in their own words, and a drafted form.
- **Metrics:** Conversations started (target: 5 or more), replies, form responses.
- **Check:** Which problem did three or more people mention unprompted?

Week 6: Lead magnet and offer shape (Part 5)

- **Focus:** build the free thing and decide the shape of the first paid thing.
- **Do:** Build a **lead magnet**: one beginner-level, one-result resource (a short guide, a reading list, a template, or a best essay repackaged). Koe says it should be small, action-oriented and made for beginners. OPINION Add it to your welcome email and a pinned link. Choose the micro offer: a short paid guide or a small number of live sessions. Write the offer on one page: reader, point A, point B, timeframe, what is included, price. Use the single-sentence goal form: outcome, number, timeframe.
- **Deliverable:** Published lead magnet; one-page offer sheet.
- **Metrics:** Lead magnet signups (from day one), new subscribers, offer interest (ask 10 people informally).
- **Check:** Did anyone who is not a friend ask how to get it?

Week 7: Soft-test the micro offer (Parts 5, 6)

- **Focus:** put a price on something and ask real people.
- **Do:** Write a short post and an email inviting people to the micro offer, and mention it near the top and the end of the essay. Koe places offers mid and end of newsletters, and says to promote at a regular rhythm because most people never hear about what you sell. OPINION / DEMO Message 10-15 warm contacts individually with the form. Do not skip the personal messages: they are the strongest channel at your size. Take payment through a simple link. Aim for the first one to five buyers.
- **Deliverable:** Offer live; first customers (or a list of reasons they declined).
- **Metrics:** Offer interest, conversations started, revenue.
- **Check:** What did the people who said no tell me?

Week 8: Deliver, learn, decision gate 2 (Parts 5, 6)

- **Focus:** deliver the micro offer well and run the week-8 review.
- **Do:** Deliver to buyers and keep notes on every question they ask. Koe's point is that early customers teach you the product and give you testimonials. OPINION Ask for permission to quote feedback. Name your **mechanism** (a short named process, with 5 candidate names, then sleep on it). Run the **week-8 review**.
- **Deliverable:** Delivered offer; testimonial notes; week-8 decision memo.
- **Metrics:** Offer interest per 100 readers, revenue, replies.
- **Check:** Would I run this offer again, and what would I change?

Week 9: Build the product, date the launch (Parts 6, 7)

- **Focus:** design the next product around what buyers actually asked.
- **Do:** Decide format: a small cohort, a short course, or a longer guide. Koe's advice is cohort first, then a cheaper standalone course, and community last, with years between stages. OPINION Outline: where learners are, where they want to be, what bridges the gap, then modules. Write the **sales page** as plain text (headline, subhead, pain list, short story, mechanism, what is included, proof, guarantee, call to action, questions). DEMO Set a **launch date** about three weeks out and close date and a price step or bonus deadline.
- **Deliverable:** Product outline; sales page v1; dated launch plan.
- **Metrics:** Offer interest (waitlist), notes published, essays.
- **Check:** Can I state the promise in one sentence with a number and a timeframe?

Week 10: Launch week 1, soft (Part 7)

- **Focus:** warm the audience without hard selling.
- **Do:** Narrow your content toward the product topic. Mention the launch near the top and in the P.S. of the weekly essay. Under your best short post each day, link the essay, not the product. DEMO Open the sales page to take orders; build while selling if you follow the pre-sell approach Koe describes, but only if you are certain you can deliver. DEMO Keep DMs going with the waitlist.
- **Deliverable:** Essay with launch mention; sales page live; first pre-sales.
- **Metrics:** Waitlist, offer interest, revenue, conversations.
- **Check:** Is anyone confused about what it is or who it is for?

Week 11: Launch week 2, harder (Part 7)

- **Focus:** make the problem vivid and the date visible.
- **Do:** List the problems the product addresses and write one post for each. Under the day's best post, add a short plug with the deadline. DEMO Send a dedicated email. Answer every question in public if you can, since most readers have the same questions. Add one piece of proof (a result from the micro offer, with permission).
- **Deliverable:** Launch email; 5+ problem posts; proof element on the page.
- **Metrics:** Revenue, offer interest, replies, unsubscribes (note them).
- **Check:** Which objection comes up most, and is it answered on the page?

Week 12: Launch week 3, close; decision gate 3 (Part 7)

- **Focus:** the final push, honest scarcity, and the week-12 review.
- **Do:** Standalone promotion posts for the last three days. Final-day email and a short reminder before the close. Koe notes that most sales land in the last day or two. DEMO Close on the stated date. Deliver the follow-through. Run the **week-12 review**.

- **Deliverable:** Closed launch; revenue and buyer count; week-12 decision memo.
- **Metrics:** All eight.
- **Check:** What did the launch teach me that the first twelve weeks of content did not?

Week 13: Debrief and the next quarter (Parts 1-7)

- **Focus:** consolidate and plan.
- **Do:** Reduce intensity: two lighter weeks of maintenance writing. Write a public or semi-public reflection (a post-mortem essay is also content). Review the dashboard across all 13 weeks. Update your five answers from the front matter. Choose the next 90 days: one growth target, one offer target, one learning target. Koe launches something new roughly every quarter. DEMO That cadence will not suit everyone. Decide what yours is.
- **Deliverable:** 90-day summary (one page), next 90-day plan (one page).
- **Metrics:** 13-week trends.
- **Check:** What would I do differently if I started again tomorrow?

Decision rules

Rules protect you from two failure modes: quitting because a week was quiet, and persisting because stopping feels like failure. Apply them mechanically and note exceptions in your log.

WEEK 4: IS THE ENGINE RUNNING?

Compare weeks 3-4 against the baseline from week 1.

Observation	Decision
You published all planned essays and at least 80% of planned notes	The rhythm is real. Continue
You missed more than a quarter of planned output	**Cut scope, not standards.** Drop the daily short-form target to 1 a day; keep the weekly essay
One post or essay clearly out-performed your median (use roughly twice as a guide, not a law)	**Double down:** write a follow-up on the same idea in a different form, and note the angle that worked
No essay or post was much above median	Do not change the content yet. Test one variable: **title and opening** only
Replies and conversations are near zero	Increase engagement time by 15 minutes and send more specific outreach. Replies to others are the cheapest lever Koe describes for beginners. OPINION
New subscribers flat while views grow	Fix the path: add the subscribe prompt and welcome email, link the essay under posts

Cut at week 4: any recurring activity that took more than 20% of your time and moved no metric. A common candidate is a platform you added "to be everywhere"; Koe's advice is one short-form platform and one long-form home. OPINION

WEEK 8: IS THERE DEMAND FOR A PAID THING?

Observation	Decision
At least a few buyers (even one to three) and positive feedback	**Double down:** write the product around the buyers' words. Raise the price slightly for the next round
Strong interest (replies, form responses) but no purchases	The offer or price is the problem, not the demand. Interview the non-buyers, simplify, and re-offer in 2-3 weeks

Observation	Decision
Little interest and weak form responses	The offer is wrong or the audience is wrong. Go back to week 5 and ask different questions. Do **not** build a bigger product on top
Offer interest per 100 readers is very low but readers are loyal	Consider a pay-what-you-think model, a paid tier for existing essays, or a reading-based product rather than a business-skills product
A single problem keeps recurring in conversations	Make that the product topic regardless of what you assumed in week 1

Cut at week 8: the lead magnet if it has attracted fewer signups than an ordinary essay with a subscribe prompt (replace it with a best essay or reading list). Cut any offer version you would not personally buy.

WEEK 12: CONTINUE, CHANGE OR STOP?

Review all 13 weeks, not just the launch.

Pattern	Decision
Subscribers growing, replies growing, at least some revenue	**Continue.** Raise the ambition of the next quarter's goal by one step, not three
Subscribers growing, revenue near zero	Writing works; the ladder does not. Spend next quarter on offer research and a lower-friction first purchase
Revenue present, subscribers flat	Traffic is the limit. Concentrate on borrowed reach: collaborations, guest pieces, recommendation swaps with peers
Neither growing despite consistent output	Examine fit before effort: who is the reader? Is the title promise clear? Are essays easy to enter? Ask five readers to describe in their own words what you write about. If they cannot, positioning is the issue
You are exhausted, output fell, signals are positive	Reduce frequency before you reduce quality. A sustainable cadence beats a heroic one

Stop rule. If after 12 weeks you have kept the rhythm, tested at least one offer honestly, and the signals are flat across every metric, that is data: possibly about the offer, possibly about the plan, possibly about the fit with what you want from this. Do not stop on a single poor week or a single failed offer. Do stop and rethink if you realize you dislike the work. Koe says discipline follows from identity and clear goals, so ask which goal you actually hold. OPINION

REFERENCE

A–E

Appendices

Reference material: exercise index, glossary, AI recipes, reality check.

- → A Exercise index
- → B Glossary
- → C AI workflow recipes
- → D Reality check
- → E Open gaps

APPENDIX A

Exercise index

Part 1-7 authors may name their exercises differently. This index lists the exercises the playbook expects to contain, grouped by theme and phrased generically. Use it to find the right exercise for a problem.

Theme	Exercise (generic)	Part
Direction	Write an anti-vision list of experiences you never want to repeat	1
	Write a minimum viable vision in 30 minutes	1
	State your reader's point A and point B in three sentences	1
	Write your mission as a transformation, not a topic	1
	Name an enemy: a way of working or living your writing opposes	1
	Answer the five questions on goal, reader, first offer, assumption, sacrifice	1
Ideas	Start an idea museum with two collections	2
	Build a source list: 3-5 idea-dense sources and 5 writers	2
	Draw a content map on paper (territories, subtopics, ideas)	2
	Run one idea through five angles	2
	Extract ten ideas from one long source	2
	Rewrite one idea in a borrowed structure	2
	Keep a five-minute reading habit and rephrase the one idea that grips you	2
	Interview yourself with an AI to find a contrarian position	2
	Coin a name for a process you already use	2
	Write the strongest opposing argument to a belief for 10 minutes	2
Free writing and audience	Write the profile bio in the "I write about X so you can Y" form	3
	Identify three outlier posts in your space and write their skeletons	3
	Dissect three posts for hook, structure, word choice and effect	3
	Write ten posts in a set of ten different structures	3
	Practice daily replies that add experience, not praise	3
	Send three specific notes a day to peers near your size	3
	Review top-performing posts monthly and rewrite them from new angles	3
Newsletter	Outline an essay with a point, three arguments, and support	4
	Write the opening 200-500 words: show what most people get wrong	4
	Write the same essay idea in two newsletter frameworks	4
	Write a welcome email	4
	Cut an essay into five standalone posts	4
	Do a quality check on density and clarity with AI critique	4
	Build a weekly footer: reader news plus one offer line	4

Theme	Exercise (generic)	Part
Offer and ladder	Write a five-question audience form	5
	Hold five listening conversations with readers	5
	Draft a one-page offer sheet (reader, A, B, timeframe, price)	5
	Write a four-session service outline with homework	5
	Map a ladder with one asset per rung and a price per rung	5
	Do the revenue back-solve with your own price and conversion	5
	Write a short message sequence for warm leads	5
Courses and products	List your ten best posts and find the common idea	6
	Fill in the avatar sheet about yourself	6
	Name your mechanism with five candidates	6
	Document one process as instructions for a new hire	6
	Dissect a product you have bought: structure, price, promise	6
	Outline modules from point A to point B	6
Landing pages and launch	Draft ten headlines for one offer and choose one	7
	Write a pain-point list of five to six qualifying items	7
	Write the page in the standard order, 600-800 words	7
	Set a launch date and a three-week content plan	7
	Write the final-day email and the short reminder	7
	Run a pre-mortem on the launch	7
Review	Compute dashboard ratios at each phase gate	8
	Write the week-4, week-8 and week-12 decision memos	8

APPENDIX B

Glossary

Terms are used the way Koe uses them, in the playbook's words. A tag shows whether the term is his coinage or a general concept he borrowed.

Term	Meaning
Anti-vision	A description of the life or work you refuse, used to find what you want by inversion
Vision / minimum viable vision	A short written picture of what you want, kept rough and revised
Point A / point B	Where your reader is now and where they want to be; the gap is your content and product
Content map	A paper map of territories, subtopics and idea slots, built from vision and anti-vision
Idea museum	A single place that stores every idea at once; often split into validated and favorite ideas
Validated idea	An idea (yours or another writer's) that visibly attracted attention
Intelligent imitation	Studying work you admire, copying its structure but not its content, and filling it with your own ideas
Swipe file	A saved collection of strong posts and structures to dissect and learn from
Structure vs idea	The claim that many writers have an arrangement problem, not an idea problem
Hook	The opening move that makes a stranger keep reading; usually a pain, a claim, a number, or a story
Open loop	A promise of something to come, used inside a piece or to link letters
Pain & Process	A newsletter shape: state the problem, then give the steps to solve it
BPAS	Big idea, Problem, Amplify, Solution; a two-part newsletter template
APAG	Attention, Perspective, Advantage, Gamify; a writing structure Koe teaches
PAS / PASTOR	Copywriting formulas: Problem-Amplify-Solution, and Problem-Amplify-Story-Testimony-Offer-Response
Awareness levels	Five stages from unaware to most aware; they shape how you write for each reader
Pyramid outline	Conclusion first, then arguments, then support
Lead magnet	A free resource offered in exchange for an email address
Stealth sales page	A public essay that sells softly because it also teaches
Micro offer / MVO	The smallest paid thing that proves demand; a low-price guide or a few paid sessions
Mechanism	The named, repeatable process at the center of a product
Cohort	A group course with a start date, fixed length, live elements and a higher price
Value ladder	A sequence of offers from free to expensive, each helping more
Build / borrow / buy	Three kinds of distribution: your own audience, someone else's, or paid
Non-needy networking	Starting real relationships by giving first, without asking for anything
Tactical stress	A self-made deadline with real stakes, such as taking orders before the product exists
You are the niche	Koe's position that a person's point of view, not a topic, defines the brand
Mission-based niche	A brand organized around a transformation, so any idea that serves it fits
Niche of one	A synonym for the above
Value creator	Koe's label for a person who researches their interests, writes about them and packages the result

Term	Meaning
Specialized generalist	Someone with several linked interests who builds one through-line
Time under attention	The idea that long reading time creates trust that short posts cannot
Exponential event	A rare post or video that grows far beyond your average, after which you double down
Fill-Empty-Use	A daily rhythm: take in ideas, clear the mind in writing, then create
Lever task	A task that moves the goal, as opposed to a maintenance task
Public journal	Treating a social account as a place to document what you learn
Build a world	Treating your archive as a connected body of work a new reader can binge
Centropic / entropic	His terms for content that builds order and clarity versus content that feeds distraction
What happened this week	A recurring footer: news, links, and one low-pressure offer
Survivorship bias	Learning only from the visible winners; relevant to every claim in this playbook

APPENDIX C

AI workflow recipes

Koe says he does not want AI to write the final words. He uses it to sharpen thinking, take apart good work, and generate raw ideas, then writes himself. DEMO / OPINION He also reports that outputs reach about 90 percent of his own quality only after repeated testing, and that a lot of raw output is unusable. DEMO The recipes below follow that stance. The prompts are the playbook's own and are meant as starting points. Edit them to your voice, and test.

Rules for all recipes. (1) You supply the opinion; the AI supplies questions, structure and friction. (2) Never publish AI wording unedited. (3) Keep a prompt library: when a prompt works, save it with a note on what you pasted in. (4) Give the AI examples of good writing and your own past work, not just instructions.

Recipe 1: Thought-partner interview (finding your unique angle)

- **Method.** Before writing, tell the AI your topic and have it interview you one question at a time until you have several real breakthroughs. Then it assembles them into an outline. Koe's version hunts for four things: where you differ from the standard approach, cases where the opposite works, unnamed things you do that deserve a name, and contrasts between two types. He reports running something like this before he writes. DEMO
- **Starter prompt.** > I want to write about [topic] for [reader]. Interview me, one question at a time. Push back on anything generic until I give a specific example. Look for: where my view differs from the common one, a surprising reversal, something I do that has no name, and a useful contrast. No praise. After about ten answers, list the strongest three insights, each with a draft name, and propose an essay outline.
- **What you do with the output.** Keep the insights and names. Throw away the outline's wording. Write the essay yourself.
- **Guardrail.** If the AI's questions are bland, give it a past essay you like as an example of the depth you want.

Recipe 2: Structure dissector (learning from great writing)

- **Method.** Paste a piece you admire and ask the AI to map its structure at two levels: the overall arrangement, and sentence-level moves. Koe teaches this as training wheels: take apart several pieces, then rewrite your own idea in each structure. DEMO / OPINION
- **Starter prompt.** > Here is a piece I admire. Break it down. First, the macro structure as an outline of moves (what each section does for the reader). Second, the opening: what technique captures attention? Third, three sentence-level techniques worth copying, with an example from the text. Fourth, a blank template I could fill with my own idea. Do not summarize the content.
- **What you do with the output.** Write your own idea into the template, with new examples and your own voice. Compare to the original and remove any phrase that echoes it.
- **Guardrail.** Emulate structure, not content. Never reuse the source's examples or distinctive phrases.

Recipe 3: Idea extraction from a source

- **Method.** Feed a book chapter, a transcript or your old writing and ask for post ideas sorted by type: paradoxes, big ideas, pain points, objections, action steps, quotes. Koe's version also asks for a small transformation arc, producing what he calls micro articles, and he says the writing itself remains his. DEMO
- **Starter prompt.** > From the text below, extract ideas I could write about. Sort them into: surprising claims, paradoxes, common mistakes, objections a skeptic would raise, practical steps, and memorable examples. For each, give one sentence on why a general reader would care. Do not write posts.
- **What you do with the output.** Pick three. Apply the five-angles exercise. Add your own experience before writing.
- **Guardrail.** If you extract from other people's work, credit them and add your own thinking. Check quotations against the source.

Recipe 4: Headline and hook generation

- **Method.** Generate many titles and openers, then choose and rework. Koe advises borrowing proven packaging for a title and keeping the substance original, and he describes producing 10-20 variants before picking. DEMO / OPINION
- **Starter prompt.** > Essay topic: [one sentence]. Reader: [who]. Write 20 titles in five styles: contrarian, number-led, question, plain promise, and story. Then for the best three, write two different opening lines each. Flag any that overpromise.
- **What you do with the output.** Choose with a human test: show three titles to a friend and ask which they would click and why. Rewrite your winner in your own voice.
- **Guardrail.** A title must be honest to the piece. Cut anything the essay cannot deliver.

Recipe 5: Introduction critique

- **Method.** Paste your first 300-500 words and ask for critique only, not a rewrite. Koe recommends hooks that show what most people get wrong, then a promise, and reviewing drafts through the eyes of a scrolling reader. OPINION / DEMO
- **Starter prompt.** > Critique the opening below for a reader who is scrolling and does not know me. Tell me: where do I lose them, what is the first concrete thing they learn, what is the promise, and what would a skeptic roll their eyes at? Give three specific edits. Do not rewrite the opening.
- **What you do with the output.** Make the edits yourself. Read the new opening aloud.
- **Guardrail.** Run it once. Repeated AI polishing flattens voice.

Recipe 6: Idea-density check

- **Method.** Ask the AI to rate how many distinct ideas each section carries and where the writing is padded or abstract. Koe's mini course describes an idea-density grader as part of drafting. DEMO
- **Starter prompt.** > For each section of this draft, list: the single idea it carries, any sentence that repeats an earlier idea, any claim without an example, and any term that is not defined. Then tell me which section is thinnest. Do not rewrite.
- **What you do with the output.** Cut repetition, add one example where a claim is bare, and define terms in plain words.
- **Guardrail.** Density is not the goal for its own sake. Your reader may want room to think.

Recipe 7 (optional): Position stress-test

- **Method.** Use the AI as a skeptical reader, not an assistant. This supports your habit of challenging assumptions.
- **Starter prompt.** > Here is my argument. Act as an intelligent critic. State the strongest objection, a case where the argument fails, and what I would have to prove for it to hold. Be brief and do not be polite for its own sake.
- **What you do with the output.** Answer the objection in the essay, or change the claim.

APPENDIX D

Reality check

Claims worth verifying before you rely on them

Koe's letters contain many figures. These are the types most worth testing against your own results.

Claim type	Why it needs care
Revenue and income figures (monthly, yearly, per-launch)	Self-reported, rounded, and used in promotion. Figures differ between letters. They often describe peak months
Audience size at a point in time	Counts across all platforms are inconsistent, and "followers" and "subscribers" are different assets
Follower-to-income ratios (for example, a dollar a follower a month)	Presented as a rule of thumb; drawn from his own audience. Your readership and offers differ
Conversion math (visitors, conversion, daily sales)	Illustrative arithmetic, not observed rates. Use for planning, then replace with your data
"Tiny audience can earn big" claims (a handful of clients, a thousand followers)	Such cases exist, but a selected few. Ask what else those people had: a network, a prior career, an existing client base
Timelines (first sale, first thousand, six figures)	These are compressed stories. The failures that preceded them are mostly outside the frame
Engagement ratios, "overperform" thresholds	Rules of thumb. Rebuild from your own median
Cause and effect (this post caused this growth)	He often credits one move for a result that had many inputs
Claims about AI	The field moves fast. Anything about tools or prompts should be retested now

Risks

Paid reposts and paid growth. Koe describes paying mid-sized accounts to repost or comment on strong content, and cites spend ranges, while also warning that content quality must carry it. OPINION / DEMO Check the rules of your platform, disclose paid promotion where required, and expect uneven results. For an essay-led publication, an earned recommendation from a respected writer is usually worth more than a purchased push. Do not buy followers or engagement.

Over-promising. Koe's offers often name a timeframe and a number as a selling device (for example, a result in seven days). DEMO Promises that sell can also disappoint. Promise what you can deliver for a typical buyer, give the process rather than a guaranteed outcome, and state what the reader still has to do. A guarantee is a promise: do not offer one you would not honor.

Income claims. Never quote Koe's income as a likely result for your readers. If you share your own earnings, say what they were, over what period, and what else contributed, and do not imply typical outcomes. Rules on earnings claims vary by country. Check yours.

Copying risk. The model rests on studying what works, which is safe at the level of structure (hooks, sequences, formats) and risky at the level of content. Rules: copy structure, not wording; do not reproduce another writer's examples or distinctive coinages; credit sources of ideas; when you borrow a framework, say so. Koe himself credits thinkers by name and then rebrands their ideas, so be careful where that line sits. A reader who can see the original will notice.

Tool and affiliate bias. Many of his steps assume his own tools and promote his products. Substitute tools that suit you, and disclose any affiliate links you add.

Hype and tone mismatch. Provocative titles, urgency and absolute statements are central to his packaging. They may not fit a reflective readership and may cost trust you already have. Test tone in small doses.

Source accuracy. Where a figure or claim matters, re-read the original letter, since the notes are summaries.

Overwork and sameness. The plan asks for two hours a day for 13 weeks. If your quality drops, reduce volume, not the care.

Quoting and attribution. If you draw on a letter for an argument, paraphrase and link. Do not reproduce his prompts or sections.

What to do if results lag

Work down this list in order. Fix the earliest broken link first.

1. **Is the output real?** Check your own tally. Many people believe they have been consistent when the log shows otherwise.
2. **Is the entry point clear?** Can a new reader tell what the piece is about and why it matters in the first few lines? Ask three readers to describe your publication in a sentence.
3. **Is the title doing its job?** Rewrite the last five titles with a clear promise. Test one variable.
4. **Is anyone discovering you?** If views are low, the problem is reach: engage with others, collaborate with peers, publish where long form is rewarded.
5. **Are visitors leaving without subscribing?** If views are fine but subscribers are low, the problem is the path: add the subscribe prompt, a welcome email, and a clear reason to subscribe.
6. **Are subscribers not opening or replying?** If so, the problem is relevance or expectation. Ask a small group what they hoped to get.
7. **Is demand for the offer missing, or the ask?** If readers engage but no one buys, interview non-buyers. Often the offer is too big, too vague or too expensive for the relationship.
8. **Is your goal compatible with your style?** If your aim is paying readers but your readers come for ideas, consider a lower-pressure paid product (a tier, an archive, a reading guide) rather than a skills course.
9. **Have you given it long enough?** Koe says growth often comes in bursts after a long flat stretch, and describes dozens of attempts before a hit. DEMO This does not prove you will see the same, but it means week 6 is too early for a verdict.

If after all of this you still see nothing, reduce the plan to its core, a weekly essay and a handful of conversations, and continue for another quarter before deciding.

APPENDIX E

Open gaps

What the source notes did not cover, and where you will have to find answers yourself.

1. **Substack-specific mechanics.** The notes describe Substack in passing. They do not cover the details of recommendations, Notes behavior, paid-tier setup, export, or current fees. Check the platform's present terms.
2. **Essay-first, non-business readerships.** Koe mostly writes to people who want to build businesses or change their lives. The notes contain very little on monetizing general-interest or literary readers. The ladder may need to be designed from scratch.
3. **Results at small scale.** There are few reliable data points for a list of a few thousand: realistic conversion, realistic first-offer revenue, realistic growth rate. Your own numbers matter more.
4. **Failures.** His letters mostly report what worked. The notes show little about launches that flopped beyond brief mentions, so base rates are unknown.
5. **Prompts in full.** The AI recipes were summarized at the method level. The original prompts were not reproduced here. Test your own versions.
6. **Legal, tax and payments.** The notes mention skipping company formation early. They do not cover tax, consumer law, refunds, VAT, or earnings-claim rules in your country.
7. **Email deliverability and list hygiene.** Not covered.
8. **Paid community, video, podcast.** The notes describe these as later-stage and mostly outside this playbook.
9. **Pricing for ideas-based products.** His price points suit business and skill products. The notes do not give tested price ranges for philosophy, writing craft or reflection products.
10. **Ethics of persuasion.** Koe argues persuasion is neutral and that selling is helping. The notes do not test where that argument fails. You should decide where your line is.
11. **Later letters.** The notes cover the letters supplied. His practice has changed over time and may have changed since.
12. **Parts 1 to 7.** This part and appendices refer to exercises the other parts are expected to contain. If a part changes an exercise, follow that part.

START TOMORROW

Your next 7 days

A short checklist to begin. One item per box. Tick when the deliverable exists.

Day 1

- [ ] Answer the five questions from the front matter in writing (30 minutes).
- [ ] Create the evidence log document and write the first entry.
- [ ] Record your baseline numbers (list size, last four essays' open rates).

Day 2

- [ ] Write the anti-vision list (15 minutes) and a minimum viable vision (30 minutes).
- [ ] Write the point A to point B sentence for your reader.
- [ ] Draft a one-line bio in the form "I write about X so you can Y" and compare it with your current one.

Day 3

- [ ] Create the idea museum. Save at least 15 items, two collections.
- [ ] List 3-5 idea-dense sources and 5 writers to check instead of a feed.

Day 4

- [ ] Draw the content map on paper: territories, subtopics, ideas.
- [ ] Choose the essay for week 3 and outline it in the pyramid form.

Day 5

- [ ] Set up the dashboard (eight metrics) and note the day of the week for your Sunday review.
- [ ] Publish your first three short posts of the plan.

Day 6

- [ ] Send three sincere, specific notes to writers near your size.
- [ ] Reply to ten posts with something from your own experience.
- [ ] Take a walk with one question: what do I most want to say this month?

Day 7

- [ ] Review the log. Write the one change for next week.
- [ ] Read Part 2 before week 2 begins.
- [ ] Rest.